

Out of Touch: How Economic News and Commentary Reduce Trust in Media

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Abstract

Americans' trust in mass media and other institutions has plummeted in recent years. I argue media and experts appear “out of touch” when economic news becomes disconnected from everyday experience, a misalignment made particularly salient by online commentary spread on social media. During the 2021–2025 “vibecession,” when consumer sentiment fell despite positive economic indicators, I show that online commentary about economic conditions aligned more closely with consumer sentiment than mainstream news. I test the implications using an experiment that varies the tone of both economic news articles and a set of anonymous comments. I find comments substantially shape readers' perceptions of public economic sentiment. Further, negative comments reduce trust in media and experts particularly when paired with positive news. Exposure to positive articles also reduces trust more among economically dissatisfied readers. Paradoxically, accurate reporting can reduce institutional trust when citizens perceive elite narratives as disconnected from public experiences.

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1 Introduction

“Everything you read in the newspapers is absolutely true except for the rare story of which you happen to have firsthand knowledge.” - Erwin Knoll

News media and other authoritative institutions have suffered steep declines in public trust in recent decades (Brenan, 2025; Ladd, Tucker, and Kates, 2018). Conventional wisdom largely attributes these declines to attacks by political leaders, particularly among Republicans (Ladd, 2012; Archer and Peterson, 2025). However, in recent years trust has plummeted across partisan lines. During the Biden presidency, trust in media among Democrats fell by 20 percentage points, four times the decline among Republicans (Brenan, 2025). These losses matter, eroding the shared factual basis needed for democratic engagement (Lippmann, 1922; Sunstein, 2018), potentially weakening electoral accountability for economic performance (de Benedictis-Kessner and Warshaw, 2020; Kayser and Peress, 2026), and feeding an anti-elite politics that casts both political and intellectual institutions as disconnected from the realities of ordinary citizens (Eyal, 2019; Merkley, 2020).

This paper proposes a new explanation for these declines rooted in the contemporary information environment: competing narratives about the economy between mainstream news and online commentary signal to audiences that media and other elites are disconnected from public experience. While a large literature debates the extent to which mainstream news shapes economic perceptions and public opinion broadly (Kinder and Kiewiet, 1981; Zaller, 1992; Hetherington, 1996; Druckman, 2001; Bennett and Iyengar, 2008; Coppock, 2023), I argue that online commentary on news and social issues from ordinary citizens forms a substantive, complementary information channel. News comments are increasingly bundled together with how Americans consume news; Stroud, Van Duyn, and Peacock (2016) finds that 77.9% of Americans have read online news comments, and this figure surely has risen as Americans continue increasing their use of the internet and social media (St. Aubin and Liedke, 2026). These news comments provide an important, unique function: they directly

signal the experiences and opinions of the mass public (Winter and Krämer, 2016; Soffer and Gordoni, 2020; Lee, Jang, and Chung, 2021; Cao, Xu, and Yang, 2023). Conversely, mainstream news content signals the beliefs of media organizations as well as the experts who are routinely cited in economic news coverage. When institutional narratives clash with public experience, I argue that these elites appear out of touch, potentially reshaping the informational foundations of electoral accountability. Rather than relying on mainstream economic reports, voters may increasingly use online commentary as a proxy for public economic experience while dismissing institutional accounts as disconnected from reality.

The 2021–2025 “vibecession,” which saw a historic decoupling of consumer sentiment and macroeconomic conditions (Scanlon, 2022; Bolhuis et al., 2024), provides a near-ideal setting in which high economic uncertainty led to a divergence between public perceptions and elite narratives. Despite strong GDP growth, low unemployment levels, and easing inflation over the course of Biden’s presidency, over half the American public — including 49% of Democrats — believed the United States economy was actually in a recession (Dickler, 2024). Lower-income households faced stagnant real wages and steep cost-of-living increases even as aggregate indicators improved in what some commentators called a “K-shaped” recovery (Dalton et al., 2021; Ludwig, 2025). However, as I show below, mainstream news coverage of the economy remained resolutely upbeat despite the negative public mood that also dominated online discussions of economic conditions. The 2024 presidential election took place against this backdrop, with the incumbent party facing an electorate whose economic perceptions diverged sharply from the indicators that traditionally predict incumbency advantage.

I describe the landscape of mainstream news about the economy by collecting and analyzing 166,000 economic news articles published in five major US dailies — the *New York Times*, *Washington Post*, *Los Angeles Times*, *Wall Street Journal*, and *Chicago Tribune* — from 2008–2025. The tone of economic news from these outlets generally tracked macroeconomic indicators, particularly in the post-pandemic period, when mainstream coverage became

largely upbeat as economic conditions improved. I then compare mainstream coverage to online commentary, analyzing 358,968 comments posted under economic news articles and videos on Reddit and YouTube. These comments provide a large-scale naturalistic record of online audience reactions to economic journalism, offering a window into the broader tone of online news commentary. Participation in these comment sections grew substantially over the sample period, underscoring the rising salience of news comments within the information environment. Then, the tone of YouTube and Reddit comments toward the economy became substantively more negative starting in 2021 as consumer sentiment (as measured by the University of Michigan Consumer Sentiment Index) began its steep decline. As a result, online comment tone during the post-pandemic period became more aligned with consumer sentiment than mainstream news, reversing a decade-long pattern. From 2021–2025, Americans inhabited an economic information environment characterized by upbeat mainstream coverage alongside persistently negative consumer sentiment reflected in online commentary.

I propose disconnect signaling theory to explain how this mismatch between mainstream news and public experience affects institutional trust. While the sociotropic view of economic voting and media effects suggests that authoritative economic news — published by established media organizations and featuring interviews with expert economists — largely shapes audiences’ views of economic conditions (Kinder and Kiewiet, 1981; Hetherington, 1996; Garz and Martin, 2021), personal experience (Healy, Persson, and Snowberg, 2017) and public consensus (Johnston and Ballard, 2016) may also affect how citizens perceive the state of the economy. When citizens’ own economic evaluations diverge from news narratives, I argue that economic news persuades less than it signals that media and experts are out of touch. Positive economic news causes readers who believe the economy is poor — for instance, those facing high prices and stagnant wages — to lose trust in the journalists and economists describing a reality they do not recognize. Then, negative online commentary highlights the disconnect between media narratives and public experience for a broader audience, further fueling distrust in media and experts. This dynamic may also extend to

political elites, as audiences may see media, experts, and public officials as part of a broader elite (Herbst, 1998; Guo and Lei, 2025). Disconnect signaling may therefore also reduce perceptions that public officials are responsive to their concerns.

An original preregistered survey experiment ($N = 2,400$, recruited via Prolific) tests the theory’s causal predictions. After first reporting their perceptions of current economic conditions, respondents were presented with an economic news article accompanied by a set of anonymous user comments, with the tone of both article and comments randomly varied. Economic news articles substantially shifted respondents’ beliefs about the economic views of journalists, economists, and even politicians, with effects more than four times larger than news’ impact on respondents’ own post-treatment evaluations of the economy. Consistent with disconnect signaling, divergence between news narratives and audience experience eroded institutional trust: positive economic news led economically dissatisfied respondents to lose trust in experts and media organizations and to see politicians as less attentive to their concerns — a backlash pattern that held independently of partisanship. Meanwhile, comment tone independently shaped perceptions of both overall economic conditions and the economic experiences of ordinary citizens, rivaling or exceeding the effects of article tone. Moreover, negative comments caused larger declines in media and expert trust when paired with positive news articles than with negative articles, showing that clashes between news content and audience reactions undercut institutional credibility.

This paper makes three contributions. First, I develop disconnect signaling as a novel theoretical mechanism by which the information environment erodes institutional trust. Leading explanations for declines in media and expert trust emphasize attacks from political elites, particularly among Republicans (Ladd, 2012; Archer and Peterson, 2025). I argue that trust erodes when mainstream news signals that elites are disconnected from public experience and show this mechanism operates independently of partisanship, potentially helping to explain recent declines in media trust among Democrats and Independents (Davern et al., 2025; Brennan, 2025). This argument inverts a longstanding concern in the literature: rather than

media misrepresentation primarily distorting public attitudes (Herbst, 1998; Jacobs et al., 2021; Furnas and LaPira, 2024), I show it can also reduce trust in media and other institutions. Moreover, disconnect signaling is not necessarily restricted to the idiosyncrasies of the post-pandemic period. Economic news emphasizes aggregate macroeconomic indicators disproportionately shaped by top earners, causing it to poorly reflect the experiences of median- and low-income households (Jacobs et al., 2021). As inequality rises, this divergence between aggregate indicators and lived economic experience may become increasingly salient.

Second, I show that online public commentary is a substantive informational channel in its own right. Much of the media effects literature focuses on debating the role of authoritative news in shaping public perceptions (Kinder and Kiewiet, 1981; Druckman, 2001; Nyhan, 2021; Coppock, 2023); I find instead that user-generated commentary shifts both first-order economic perceptions and second-order beliefs about how other citizens perceive the economy, even in the presence of contrary institutional messaging. These findings contribute to an emerging literature on the political effects of online commentary (Lee, 2012; Winter and Krämer, 2016; Soffer and Gordoni, 2020; Anspach and Carlson, 2020; Lee, Jang, and Chung, 2021; Cao, Xu, and Yang, 2023), complementing existing evidence that citizens respond strongly to the judgments and reactions of ordinary citizens in offline contexts (Fein, Goethals, and Kugler, 2007; Johnston and Ballard, 2016). Moreover, the findings help explain how social media shapes political attitudes beyond mechanisms such as selective exposure (Messing and Westwood, 2014) and algorithmic curation (Guess et al., 2023), by highlighting the continuous visibility of peer reactions across digital platforms. As news consumption increasingly occurs in online social environments, these social signals become a central input into perceptions of public opinion.

Finally, I provide new evidence and a potential new mechanism for the post-pandemic consumer-sentiment gap. Drawing on original corpora of 166,000 economic news articles from five major national dailies (2008–2025) and 358,968 social media comments on economic news and videos (2008–2024), I document a sustained disconnect at the core of the

post-pandemic period. Economic news tone tracked positive macroeconomic fundamentals — refuting accounts that attribute the sentiment gap to media negativity bias (Harris and Sojourner, 2024) — while user commentary grew persistently negative. The experimental results suggest that such unofficial economic commentary offsets positive institutional signals, independently shaping readers’ economic perceptions. Positive economic news coverage decreases expert and media trust for aggrieved audiences, eroding the sociotropic link between authoritative news and economic perceptions (Kinder and Kiewiet, 1981; Hetherington, 1996; Garz and Martin, 2021). Voters may remain sociotropic — but instead of relying on societal reports of economic conditions from news media, they construct inferences about public economic experience from online commentary while dismissing institutional accounts as disconnected from reality.

The paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 describes the disconnect between economic news and consumer sentiment: especially in recent years, economic news was overly positive and increasingly unrepresentative, while online commentary was regularly negative. Section 3 develops the disconnect signaling theory. Section 4 describes the experimental setup used to test the hypotheses. Section 5 presents the results. The final section concludes.

2 A Disconnect Between Economic News and Audience Reactions

During the 2021–2025 “vibecession” (Scanlon, 2022), a striking divergence emerged between macroeconomic indicators and consumer sentiment in the United States. While the COVID-19 pandemic brought with it a sharp recession, high unemployment, and substantial inflation, the Biden presidency oversaw a rapid return to relatively healthy macroeconomic conditions. By the latter half of Biden’s term, GDP growth was strong, unemployment was low, and inflation rates had eased considerably. However, throughout this period consumer sentiment remained persistently depressed, with over half the American public (both Democrats and

Republicans alike) believing the United States economy was actually in a recession (Dickler, 2024). This disconnect reflected genuine ambiguity in economic conditions; despite low inflation rates, prices remained substantially elevated relative to pre-pandemic levels, creating a gap that is difficult to convey in conventional economic reporting (Ludwig, 2025). Macroeconomists have proposed numerous explanations of this anomaly (e.g., the improper weighting of borrowing costs in consumer sentiment models); for the purposes of this paper, my aim is not necessarily to explain the causes of this anomaly but rather to ask what political effects lay downstream of such a prominent disconnect.

In this section, I provide empirical evidence for two predictions about how the consumer sentiment anomaly manifested itself in the broader information environment, which in turn motivates the theory of disconnect signaling presented in Section 3. I first predict that positive macroeconomic indicators were reflected in upbeat mainstream economic news coverage that would have directly conflicted with readers’ own economic perceptions. This prediction is largely informed by the sociotropic economic voting literature, which argues that mainstream news coverage focusing on national level economic indicators shapes public evaluations of economic conditions (Kinder and Kiewiet, 1981; Hetherington, 1996; Garz and Martin, 2021; Jacobs et al., 2021; Shapiro, Sudhof, and Wilson, 2022).¹ A disconnect between news coverage and economic conditions is not unprecedented — economic coverage has at times been substantially more negative than underlying conditions (Patterson, 1994). However, the 2021–2025 period presents an unusual case in the opposite direction: mainstream coverage tracked improving macroeconomic fundamentals, while public sentiment remained markedly more negative. The second prediction is that this negative consumer sentiment was reflected in broadly available online reactions from ordinary citizens to economic news. The internet and social media allow ordinary citizens to comment on and discuss news and social issues online; such user-generated content arguably captures more public attention than hard news (Bakshy, Messing, and Adamic, 2015; Kim and York, 2025). Comment sec-

¹Although it should be noted that the evidence on the extent to which news coverage directly affects economic perceptions and voting is mixed — see Kayser and Peress (2026).

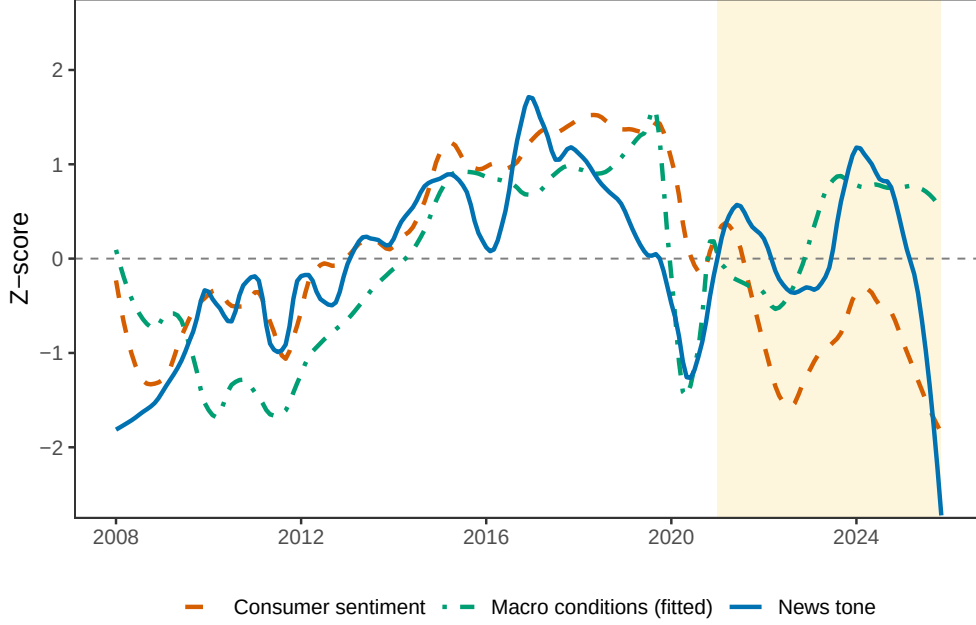
tions specifically are a routine part of how Americans interact with online news: a nationally representative survey finds that 77.9% of Americans have read online news comments and over half report both reading and posting them (Stroud, Van Duyn, and Peacock, 2016). Despite this reach, comments attached directly to news content remain comparatively understudied. Yet as I show below, they provide a broad, continuously generated information venue that surfaces citizens’ experiences and evaluations of the economy, one that differs from mainstream news.

To establish the scope of the divergence between consumer sentiment and mainstream economic news coverage, I collect and analyze all articles (N=166,000) about the US economy published in five major national dailies — the *New York Times*, *Washington Post*, *Los Angeles Times*, *Wall Street Journal*, and *Chicago Tribune* — from 2008 through 2025, using ProQuest TDM Studio. These five outlets are among the highest-circulation national dailies whose economic framing is widely followed by television news, wire services and regional outlets (Gans, 2004). Further, as local newspapers have closed or cut staff, national outlets increasingly constitute the economic news environment for most readers (Abernathy, 2018). I use the Shapiro, Sudhof, and Wilson (2022) economic news sentiment lexicon developed specifically for economic and financial journalism to measure the economic tone of each article — see Appendix A.1 for additional details on data collection and tone measurement. I also collect the University of Michigan Index of Consumer Sentiment as a measure of public economic mood, along with monthly macroeconomic indicators: national GDP growth (Federal Reserve Bank of Chicago monthly GDP index), the unemployment rate, and changes in the Consumer Price Index (Bureau of Labor Statistics).

Figure 1 plots all three series — news tone, a regression-weighted composite of the macroeconomic indicators, and consumer sentiment — standardized to z-scores.² The figure shows that news tone, macro conditions, and consumer sentiment move together through 2020,

²The macro conditions composite weights were determined by regressing news tone on unemployment, inflation, and GDP growth. Unemployment is the most heavily weighted predictor, followed by inflation and GDP growth. Further details are in Appendix A.3.

Figure 1: Economic News Tone, Macro Conditions, and Consumer Sentiment



Notes: Monthly economic news tone (Shapiro et al. score, five major dailies), macro conditions (regression-weighted composite of unemployment, inflation, and GDP growth fitted to news tone), and University of Michigan consumer sentiment index, all standardized to z-scores. Thin lines are monthly values; thick lines are LOESS smooths.

with minor variation. Consistent with previous work linking macroeconomic indicators to news coverage (Soroka, Stecula, and Wlezien, 2014; Jacobs et al., 2021; Kayser and Peress, 2026), a vector autoregression analysis and Granger-causality test suggest that changes in macroeconomic conditions predict future news tone (Appendix A.7). The post-pandemic consumer sentiment anomaly is clearly visible beginning in 2021, as consumer sentiment falls sharply and remains depressed while macro conditions bounce back quickly after initial pandemic losses. Critically, during this period I observe that news tone tracks macro indicators, diverging from consumer sentiment — contrary to some accounts (e.g., Harris and Sojourner (2024)), economic news was not unusually negative. By early 2025, news tone drops sharply and reconverges with consumer sentiment.³ These patterns hold across all five

³The 2025 drop in news tone could reflect forward-looking coverage of anticipated macroeconomic deterioration due to trade policy rather than a decoupling from fundamentals (cf. Soroka, Stecula, and Wlezien, 2014). The broader pattern of variation across presidential administrations is also suggestive of partisan dynamics in economic coverage. The key finding for the present study is that the 2021–2024 period demonstrates sustained divergence between news tone and public sentiment at scale, motivating the experimental

outlets individually; no single publication drives the result (Appendix A.2).

Of course, partisan dynamics challenge the divergence interpretation. The sample of mainstream news does not include hyperpartisan, conservative-leaning media outlets such as Fox News or Breitbart, which could have covered the economy especially negatively during Biden’s presidency. However, surveys of Democrat and Independent voters reveal that economic pessimism during this period was not confined to Republicans: a Pew survey reports that in 2024 only 37% of Democrats held a positive view of the economy (compared to over 40% in 2018), while another poll found that 49% of Democrats felt the United States was in a recession (Doherty, 2025; Dickler, 2024). Independents report even more negative economic views during the same time period, suggesting that the scope of the anomaly extends beyond purely partisan news environments. Taken together, these patterns imply a broader misalignment between economic news and public economic evaluations in recent years.

Next, to describe online user commentary about the economy, I collect news links, videos, and user comments from both Reddit (a US-based news aggregator and social media platform) and YouTube. These platforms are not the only channels through which economic discussion circulates online, but their comments provide a rich and accessible source of ordinary users’ reactions to mainstream news content. Reddit users submit external links (e.g., to news stories) as posts within topic-specific communities known as “subreddits,” while other users respond through nested comment threads. These comment sections attract substantial engagement and may be read more extensively by Reddit users than the linked news article itself (Glenski, Pennycuff, and Weninger, 2017). YouTube, meanwhile, is one of the most widely used news and media platforms online, with over 84% of US adults reporting having used the platform, compared to 26% for Reddit and 21% for Twitter/X (Gottfried and Park, 2025). YouTube is especially useful for my analysis because it hosts content published by mainstream news outlets such as CNBC and Fox News. This news content in video form is widely viewed and, importantly for my purposes, attracts hundreds to thousands of reaction

test of how such disconnect affects attitudes.

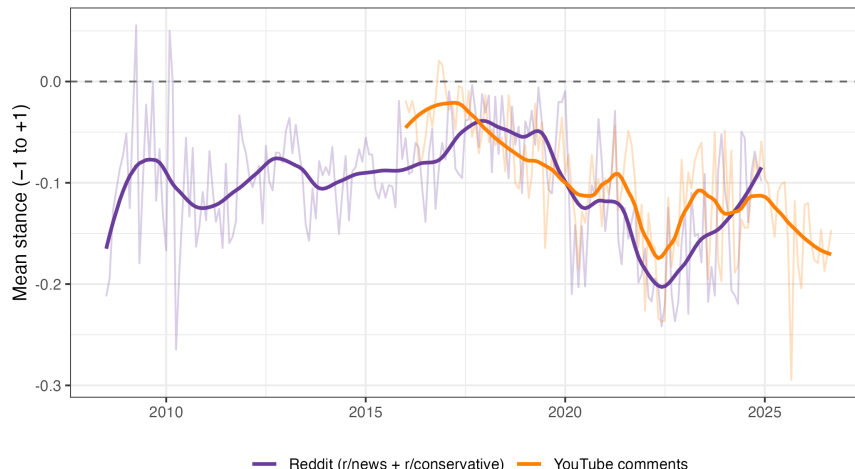
and discussion comments from YouTube users, which are prominently displayed directly next to or beneath each video. Together, Reddit and YouTube comment sections provide a large-scale, naturalistic record of how online audiences interact with and respond to mainstream news content, offering a window into the broader tone of online news commentary.

To identify US economic news posts and videos, I leverage specific features of each platform. On Reddit, I collect a random sample of economic news posts submitted to `r/news` (the highest-traffic subreddit focused on US news) as well as `r/Conservative` to guard against Reddit’s liberal skew (Gottfried and Park, 2025) between 2008 and 2024. On YouTube, I collect all videos about the US economy posted by any of the CNN, CNBC, BBC, Fox News, or MS Now official YouTube channels between 2016 and 2025. I then collect the 10–16 most popular user comments under each Reddit post and YouTube video; on both platforms, comments are sorted automatically by popularity ensuring that the most popular user comments are also the most widely viewed. I assign each comment a stance label toward the US economy using `gpt-4.1-mini` (-1 = negative economic evaluation, 0 = neutral or off-topic, $+1$ = positive). In total I collect 21,314 posts and 219,299 comments from Reddit and 15,004 videos with 139,669 comments from YouTube. See Appendix A.1 for details on corpus construction and classification.

Figure 2 shows that comments about the economy on both platforms are persistently negative throughout the sample period. This negativity deepens markedly during the 2021–2025 period; online commentary mirrors declining consumer sentiment levels. These results are not purely driven by partisan outlets — the same shift is present within both conservative-leaning and liberal-leaning subreddits and YouTube news channels (though it is perhaps unsurprisingly largest within the `/r/conservative` subreddit and Fox News; see Figure A5). This shift in negativity is substantive: after the pandemic, up to 20% of economic news threads on `r/news` had at least three of their four most popular comments expressing negative economic evaluations compared to less than 7% in 2015 (Figure A3). Additionally, negative comments are prevalent both on positive and negative news: even on Reddit posts sharing

positive economic news articles, negative comments outnumber positive ones by up to a factor of five (Figure A4).

Figure 2: Mean Online Comment Tone on Economic News

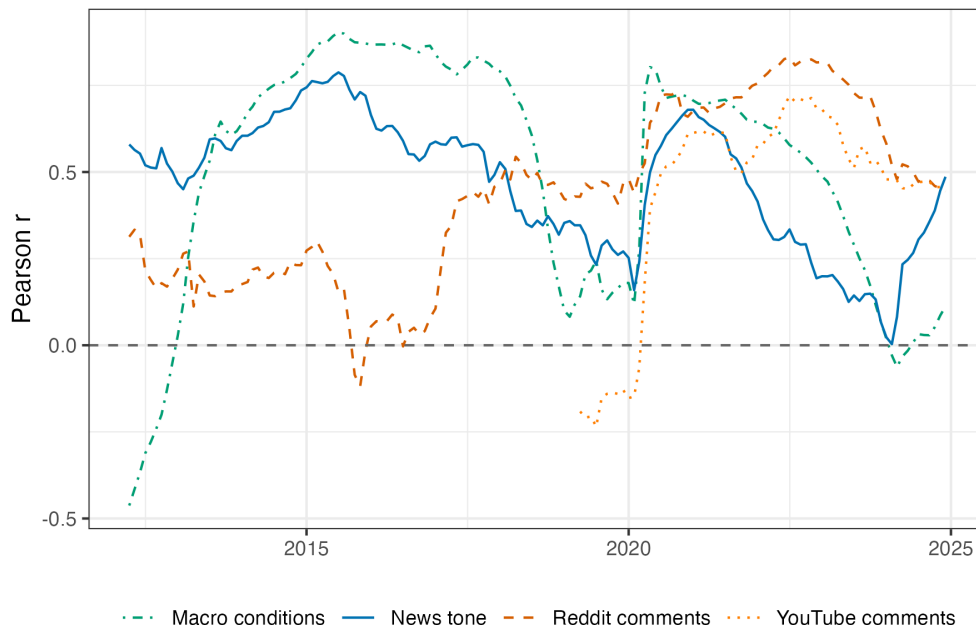


Notes: Mean comment stance on economic news, Reddit (r/news + r/Conservative combined; purple) vs. YouTube (orange). Stance coded -1 (negative), 0 (neutral), $+1$ (positive) via GPT-4.1-mini (both platforms). Thin lines are monthly means; thick lines are LOESS smooths. Because the two platforms' comment histories span different lengths of calendar time (Reddit: 2008–2024; YouTube: 2016–present), the smooths use a common fixed 36-month bandwidth rather than a common span, so the two curves reflect the same amount of temporal smoothing. Dashed line marks zero.

Figure 3 integrates these findings, plotting rolling 48-month Pearson correlations of news and comment tone against consumer sentiment (Appendix Figure A6 disaggregates by subreddit; the results are substantively similar). Through the 2008–2016 period, news tone tracks consumer sentiment tightly with correlations as high as 0.8. By contrast, Reddit comments during this period are weakly correlated with consumer sentiment. However, news tone becomes strikingly less correlated with consumer sentiment in 2021–2025, plunging nearly to 0 by 2024. During this period, comment tone on Reddit and YouTube replaces mainstream news as the stronger correlate of consumer sentiment, reaching correlations of 0.8 and 0.6 respectively. This analysis demonstrates how audience commentary online constitutes an increasingly informative signal about how citizens actually experience the economy, one that can diverge sharply from the institutional signal carried by news coverage.

Finally, this data allows me to also show that online commentary has become an increas-

Figure 3: Rolling Correlations with Consumer Sentiment



Notes: Rolling 48-month Pearson correlation with the University of Michigan consumer sentiment index. Blue/solid = economic news tone (Shapiro et al. score); green/dot-dash = macro conditions composite; orange/dashed = Reddit comments (r/news + r/Conservative combined); orange/dotted = YouTube comments. The YouTube series begins later than the others because it requires enough non-missing months within each 48-month window to yield a stable estimate (YouTube comment data begin in 2016). Dashed horizontal line marks zero correlation.

ingly salient part of the environment surrounding news consumption. Across both platforms, participation in comments has grown substantially in absolute terms, and on YouTube (where a view-count denominator is available) relative to the popularity of the underlying video as well. Although comment volume and voting are imperfect measures of engagement, their growth provides evidence that commentary has become a more active and visible venue for public reaction to news. The detailed measures are reported in Appendix A.4.

In this section, I show that mainstream economic news tracks macroeconomic indicators, creating a striking divergence during recent years between coverage tone and audiences' own perceptions of economic conditions. Further, I show that audience perceptions are reflected in negative online commentary about the economy. These comments increasingly shape how audiences encounter economic news, even as their downstream political effects remain largely unexamined. Institutional coverage during the 2021–2025 period was sharply at odds with

both audiences’ own experiences and this salient online commentary, motivating my primary research question: what are the impacts of this disconnect on political attitudes? In the following section I develop the theory of disconnect signaling: the mismatch between official economic information and perceptions of public sentiment shaped by both lived experiences and online commentary causes elites to appear out of touch. When authoritative economic signals systematically diverge from public economic sentiment, mainstream news loses credibility as a trusted interpreter of economic reality. Under such conditions, economic reporting ceases to function primarily as persuasive information and instead becomes a cue that media and other elites are out of touch with ordinary Americans.

3 A Theory of Disconnect Signaling

In recent years, trust in mainstream media has declined dramatically (particularly among Democrats and Independents) (Ladd, Tucker, and Kates, 2018; Brennan, 2025). Moreover, broader forms of institutional distrust persist in the form of skepticism toward experts (Eyal, 2019), members of the establishment (Orth, 2025) and the growing success of populist politicians in the United States and abroad (Epstein, 2025). Existing explanations attribute these trends to substantive failures of elite responsiveness and strategic elite attacks on media credibility (Ladd, 2012; Guriev, Melnikov, and Zhuravskaya, 2021; Rodrik, 2021; Silva and Wratil, 2023). However, as the preceding analysis demonstrates, how members of the media discuss important issues like the economy has diverged substantially from how members of the public view and discuss these issues online. This contrast between elite and public perspectives is increasingly visible between mainstream news and the heavily trafficked comment sections of YouTube, Reddit, news websites, and other social media platforms. Qualitative evidence suggests that such discrepancies between elites and ordinary citizens fuel institutional distrust: Kowalski (2025) finds that citizens not only perceive economic data as disconnected from their own experiences, but also interpret the prominence of such data in

media discourse as evidence that elites and experts are disconnected from the concerns of ordinary people.

I argue that the disconnect between economic news coverage and public perceptions of economic conditions shaped by online information drives perceptions of elites as out of touch, ultimately fueling institutional distrust. This mechanism operates through second-order beliefs generated by different sources of news and information. The institutional origins of news coverage mean that news signals what media and other elites believe about the world, affecting what readers believe about what these elites believe (second-order beliefs). Meanwhile, ordinary citizens' economic perceptions, and particularly their perceptions of public experience,⁴ can be informed by both lived experience and online commentary. Elites appear disconnected when citizens believe that those who govern, advise, and inform them hold a fundamentally different understanding of the world; when audiences' perceptions of elite beliefs conflict with their perceptions of public experience, elites appear out of touch.

This framework allows for two pathways for the information environment to signal disconnect. First, news that conflicts with readers' own economic perceptions could make its institutional sources appear disconnected from reality. The possibility of such a divergence follows from an asymmetry in how economic news could affect first- and second-order beliefs. Classic research on sociotropic economic evaluations suggested that news shapes citizens' perceptions of the broader economy (Kinder and Kiewiet, 1981; Hetherington, 1996), but empirical support for this argument is mixed (Kayser and Peress, 2026).⁵ News might have minimal effects on issue attitudes and beliefs (Bennett and Iyengar, 2008), especially in the

⁴In the context of economic news, perceptions of public experience and first-order economic perceptions are tightly connected. The state of the economy is an aggregate welfare claim — perceptions of economic conditions are largely constituted by reader perceptions of community economic experience (Kinder and Kiewiet, 1981; Ansolabehere, Meredith, and Snowberg, 2014; Bisbee and Zilinsky, 2023). The experimental results support this intuition; news and comments move both first-order economic perceptions and second-order beliefs about the economic perceptions of ordinary citizens in the same direction. Elites appear out of touch when readers perceive elite views of the economy to diverge from their own — or from what they perceive ordinary citizens to be experiencing.

⁵Even Hetherington (1996) found that media consumption was associated with economic evaluations in 1992 but not in 1984 or 1988, while personal economic experience consistently predicted those evaluations and generally had larger effects.

context of economic news where citizens have relatively direct information about economic conditions through their own experiences (Healy, Persson, and Snowberg, 2017; Mutz, 1992). These findings suggest that citizens’ first-order beliefs about the economy may be relatively resistant to contrary news. However, news may substantially shape readers’ beliefs about how journalists, experts, or other elites perceive economic conditions. If news shifts these second-order beliefs about elites more than it shifts readers’ first-order perceptions, the resulting gap can lead readers to perceive institutional sources as out of touch with economic reality.⁶

The second pathway focuses on the alternative sociotropic signals provided by online commentary. While the preceding analysis showed that comments reflect public sentiment in the aggregate, they may also shape individual readers’ perceptions. Similarly to how audience reactions (e.g., applause, laughter, or dismay) can affect how observers judge political speeches in offline contexts (Fein, Goethals, and Kugler, 2007), a growing body of literature shows how online reader comments also shape audiences’ perceptions of the prevailing opinion climate (Winter and Krämer, 2016; Soffer and Gordoni, 2020; Lee, Jang, and Chung, 2021; Cao, Xu, and Yang, 2023). Johnston and Ballard (2016) shows that public consensus can be more persuasive than expert testimony in informing economic judgments; comments interpreted as authentic expressions of ordinary citizens may serve as an alternative sociotropic signal that can compete with the aggregate indicators presented in mainstream coverage. Online news comments are increasingly salient as Americans consume more news using the Internet and social media (St. Aubin and Liedke, 2026). When these signals of public experience diverge from institutional accounts, elites appear out of touch with ordinary citizens.

Disconnect signaling may then manifest in several downstream political attitudes. First, citizens may trust experts and news media less; the media organizations that produce the

⁶This mechanism does not require readers to reject conflicting information or for news to “backfire” (Nyhan, 2021; Coppock, 2023). Rather, conflicting news can prompt readers to draw inferences about the beliefs of journalists, experts, and other institutional actors. In this respect, the mechanism differs from classic motivated reasoning accounts: instead of rejecting news information because it conflicts with prior beliefs, readers use the conflict to make inferences about elites’ own beliefs and credibility.

news and the experts whose perspectives are often featured in the news are the most proximal targets for trust declines when news narratives conflict with reader perceptions. Trust in experts and media organizations has eroded broadly; existing accounts emphasize partisan elite cueing (Ladd, 2012; Archer and Peterson, 2025; Guess et al., 2021; Eyal, 2019) although Ladd (2012) also finds that some properties of news itself (tabloid-style coverage) can erode trust. The disconnect signaling mechanism is distinctive yet complementary, predicting that trust can decline when news — even factually correct reporting — fails to reflect audience perceptions.

Second, citizens may be less likely to believe that politicians care about their concerns, a political attitude related to perceptions of elite responsiveness (Eulau and Karps, 1977; Craig, Niemi, and Silver, 1990). Political elites frequently misperceive public opinion (Broockman and Skovron, 2018; Walgrave et al., 2023), and some evidence shows that these representation gaps fuel anti-elite sentiment (Silva and Wratil, 2023). Conflict between news coverage and reader beliefs could shape perceptions that politicians care about the concerns of the public if readers associate news coverage with the beliefs of political elites along with media and experts. Readers may infer that politicians rely on mainstream news for information (Herbst, 1998), or may simply treat media, experts and politicians as broadly undifferentiated elites (Guo and Lei, 2025). However, negative economic information can affect evaluations of politicians through standard retrospective logic (Lewis-Beck, 1988; Fiorina, 1981), independent of the disconnect mechanism. As perceptions of the economy decline, politicians and public officials can be blamed for poor conditions directly. Therefore, my (preregistered) expectation is that effects of economic news on trust in media and experts are most diagnostic of the disconnect signaling mechanism.

Third, disconnect signaling could increase people-centric populism. Populism is typically defined as a combination of anti-elite attitudes and people-centric preferences (Mudde, 2004); trust in media and experts and responsiveness perceptions capture the anti-elite dimension, while people-centric populism captures normative preferences for governance by ordinary

people rather than elites (Castanho Silva et al., 2020). This is politically consequential but several steps down the causal chain, requiring that citizens translate institutional discontent into populist preferences. Prior work linking representation failures to populist attitudes finds mixed evidence: while Silva and Wratil (2023) find small effects of representational gaps on anti-elite attitudes, they find no effects on people-centric populist attitudes.

The first hypothesis tests the first pathway through readers’ prior beliefs about the economy: disconnect arises when reader priors about the economy conflict with news articles’ authoritative signals about economic conditions. Thus, readers’ prior economic beliefs will be the key moderator⁷ that affects how economic news affects attitudes associated with elite disconnect: trust in media and experts, perceptions that politicians care about ordinary citizens’ concerns, and people-centric populist sentiment. Economically dissatisfied readers exposed to positive economic news experience maximal disconnect, while economically satisfied readers experience none.

H1 (Article Backlash). Positive articles (compared to negative articles) decrease trust in media and experts (H1a), perceptions that politicians care (H1b), and increase people-centric populism (H1c) more for economically dissatisfied respondents.

The second set of hypotheses tests the second disconnect pathway: conflict between news and online comments as an alternative signal of public opinion. The article backlash hypothesis depends on mismatch between readers’ economic priors and news; I also predict that mismatch between online comments about economic conditions and experiences and news causes disconnect perceptions. Concretely, I hypothesize a mismatch effect rather than a general negativity effect: negative comments undermine trust because they conflict with an article’s positive signal, not because negative comments are independently more

⁷Income, perceived socioeconomic status, and personal economic hardship are plausible alternative moderators, but the disconnect mechanism operates through perceived mismatch between one’s beliefs about the economy and the signal conveyed by news coverage. A high-income respondent who nonetheless views the economy pessimistically — common during recent years — should experience the same disconnect as a low-income pessimist, because in both cases the positive article contradicts their understanding of economic reality. Measuring economic pessimism directly captures this perceptual mismatch, whereas objective indicators would misclassify respondents whose perceptions diverge from their material circumstances. Appendix results confirm this reasoning: income does not moderate disconnect effects (Table A13).

consequential than positive ones.

H2 (Comment Mismatch). Negative comments decrease trust in media and experts (H2a), perceptions that politicians care (H2b), and increase populist attitudes (H2c) more in the context of positive news.

4 Experimental Design

I tested the causal effects of the mismatch mechanism using an original 2×2 survey experiment fielded in late February 2026 on Prolific. 2,400 participants were recruited; 2,249 were retained after excluding respondents who completed the survey too quickly, failed attention checks, or were flagged by bot detection.⁸ To compare the effects of official news articles to user commentary, I showed participants an economic news article paired with user comments, randomly assigning the economic attitude of both article and comments. Specifically, after collecting pretreatment covariates (including perceptions of current economic conditions), participants read either a positive or negative economic news article accompanied by a set of four neutral or negative user comments.⁹ This mirrors the design of comment sections on news sites and on YouTube, where comments are hosted directly below the main content (on Reddit, comments are shown underneath the linked article’s headline). Participants were also given the option to leave their own additional comment. Post-treatment outcome measures were collected immediately after stimuli exposure.

Table 1 summarizes the design, which allows me to cleanly test both the article backlash (H1) and comment mismatch (H2) hypotheses. The neutral comment condition allows me to

⁸These exclusion criteria were preregistered. Appendix B provides additional details of the exclusion criteria and Appendix D shows that experimental results including all respondents are substantively similar.

⁹I did not test a comment condition with positive comments. This decision was both theoretically informed and motivated by budget and power constraints. I also note that positive economic comments appeared to be incredibly rare — positive economic comments only composed 3% of the total comments in the Reddit economic news sample.

The control condition used neutral comments as a baseline condition rather than a no-comment baseline, holding layout and cognitive load constant while varying comment tone only. Additionally, I chose to use sets of all-negative or all-neutral comments in order to provide the simplest test of comment tone given sample size constraints.

test the effect of positive news articles vs. negative news articles (H1) without an interference effect from comment tone. Then, the 2×2 design varying both comment and article tone allows me to isolate the mismatch mechanism from general negativity effects. If negative comments have a larger effect (compared to neutral comments) when paired with a positive article, this interaction provides evidence for the mismatch mechanism: people respond particularly negatively when the article’s portrayal of the economy conflicts with what they see ordinary people saying in the comments.

	Neutral Comments	Negative Comments
Positive Article	↓ Trust in Media, Experts for Economically Negative (H1)	↓ Trust in Media, Experts for Everyone (H2)
Negative Article	No change in Trust in Media, Experts	No change in Trust in Media, Experts

Table 1: Experimental conditions with expectations for trust in media and experts outcome informed by theoretical hypotheses.

The negative and positive news articles were constructed to vary only in tone while keeping all other features similar. Each article also contained a quote from an expert economist. The topic of the news article was also randomly assigned between general economic conditions and unemployment — consistent with the preregistered analysis plan, all experimental results average over these topic conditions (disaggregated results available in Appendix C.5). The comment sets were identical across conditions (although the order of the comments was randomized). Negative comments were sourced from Reddit and pilot data and expressed a mix of general economic frustration and specific grievances about the price of groceries and the job market. Neutral comments asked questions about the article or made tangents relevant to information in the article without making economic judgments. Extensive pretesting and manipulation checks confirmed both that the tone of the article and comments were received as intended and that the stimuli were judged to be highly realistic (Appendix C.5). Figure 4 shows the positive general economic conditions article and negative comments — the mismatch condition. Stimuli screenshots for other conditions are shown in Appendix B.2.

Figure 4: Example Stimulus: Mismatch Condition

ECONOMY

U.S. Economy Shows Fresh Momentum In 2026 Q1

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The American economy is showing signs of recovery. After a disappointing Q4, recent data suggests that GDP growth in early 2026 is on track to exceed expectations amidst cooling inflation and a rewarming job market.

"This steady growth will mean tangible benefits for everyday Americans," said Michael Rennison, chief U.S. economist at Beacon Policy Research. "More jobs, easing prices, and real income gains—that's the trifecta."

The numbers back up the optimism. Last week's data revealed that average weekly earnings jumped 1.42% after inflation over the past month. Retail spending rose 3.3% year-over-year and ticked up 0.6% from January alone—outpacing what economists predicted just weeks ago.

Now Wall Street is betting the momentum will carry through February, with major banks projecting the S&P 500 could climb another 2–3% before the month closes.

READER COMMENTS

RK
NY 1 3H AGO

There are no jobs available in our area, despite a lot of businesses having up hiring signs. Prices in the grocery store are WAY up. It's getting harder and harder to get by.

👍 7

Brian
LA 1 8H AGO

Every where I look rents, mortgages, food is skyrocketing I'm single, no kids and I'm like still uncomfortable with the average rent price for a 1br in my area. I'm asking real questions because I literally have no idea how people make it with a household income of 60k with dependents in my area.

👍 3

kate
FL 1 1D AGO

Things keep getting more expensive to buy but minimum wage hasn't increased in 30 years. Even if you get a degree, the job market is horrible. The American dream doesn't exist anymore.

👍 2

User123
USA 1 2D AGO

I don't know anyone who is doing well financially in these times.

👍 2

Notes: Positive article (left) with negative comments (right). Stimuli were presented as HTML-rendered pages to increase realism. See Appendix B for all stimulus screenshots.

The primary disconnect outcome was trust in experts and media, a three-question index combining trust in media, perceptions of experts as out of touch, and trust in experts. I also measured “politicians care,” using an index combining the classic ANES measure “Public officials don’t care about people like me” with two other anti-elite questions drawn from recent literature (Oliver and Rahn, 2016; Castanho Silva et al., 2020). People-centric populism was additionally measured based on a validated scale (Castanho Silva et al., 2020; Bertsou and Caramani, 2022).¹⁰ In the empirical analyses below, I reversed the measure of

¹⁰Here I note a minor deviation from the preregistration which combined people-centric populism and “politicians care” into a single six-item disconnect composite (H1a/H2a); trust in media and experts was

people-centric populism so that positive values for all dependent variables indicate greater disconnect. I also measured economic perceptions pre-treatment and post-treatment and additionally collected measures of second-order economic beliefs — that is, what respondents believed the typical member of the media, typical expert, typical politician, and ordinary citizen thought about the economy. All questions were based on 5-point Likert scales.

The experimental design, analysis plan, and advance interpretations of results were approved by New York University’s IRB (IRB-FY2026-10976) and preregistered at OSF (<https://osf.io/4szgp>). Design details including exact stimuli, measures, and exclusion criteria are reported in Appendix B; sample demographics, balance, and attrition checks are reported in Appendix B.5. No substantive or significant differential attrition was found between groups.

5 Results

I begin with analysis of how the news and comment treatments affect economic perceptions and second-order beliefs, then present the hypothesis tests investigating how disconnect signaling affects trust in media and experts, “politicians care” perceptions, and populism. I test the two theoretical pathways presented in Section 3: through contrasts between elite signals in news and reader priors about the economy (the article backlash hypothesis); and through contrasts with user commentary (the comment mismatch hypothesis).

All models are estimated using OLS with HC2-robust standard errors. Consistent with the preregistered analysis plan, no family-wise correction is applied across hypotheses.¹¹ All models also include preregistered covariates collected prior to treatment assignment: economic perceptions, media and expert trust, anti-elite and populist attitudes, news interest,

H1b/H2b. The main text reports sub-indices separately and relabels them (trust in media and experts = H1a/H2a; “politicians care” (elite responsiveness) = H1b/H2b; populism = H1c/H2c) because they respond differently to the treatments. The composites are reported in Table A18.

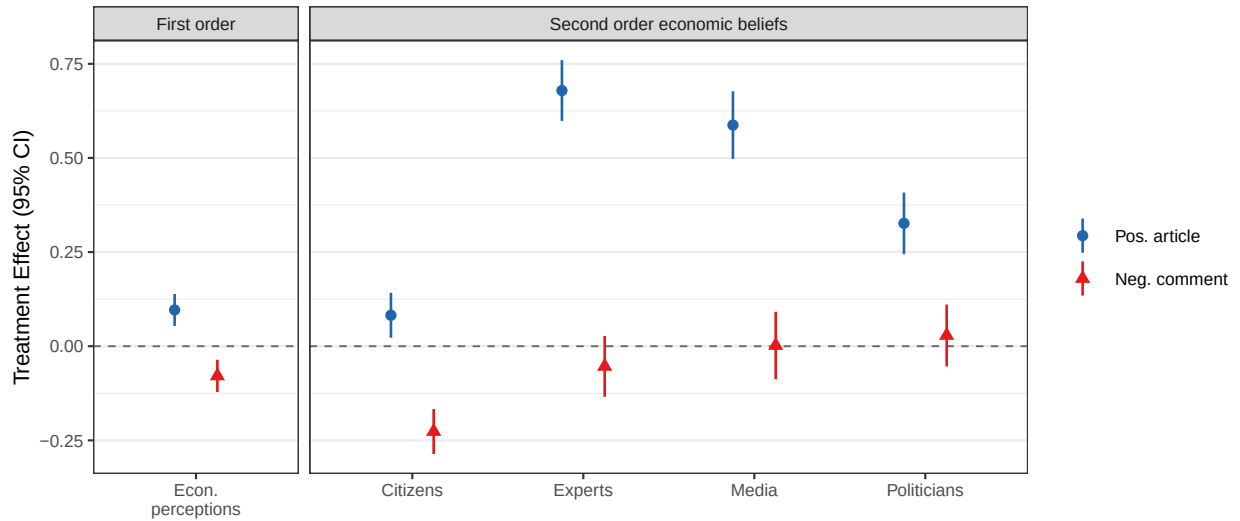
¹¹Each test is an independent theoretical claim at $\alpha = 0.05$ (Rubin, 2021). In any case, all of the statistically significant primary hypothesis tests are highly significant and would survive Holm-Bonferroni corrections.

partisanship, education, and income. Regression tables are available in Appendix D.

5.1 News and Comments Affect Second-Order Beliefs

Disconnect signaling theory predicts that news articles signal the beliefs of elites, while news comments signal the beliefs of the general public. I test this first layer of the causal chain: to what extent does exposure to different economic news and comments actually affect experimental respondents' perceptions of the economy and their beliefs about the economic beliefs of other groups — citizens, politicians, media organizations, and economic experts? While sociotropic theories of economic voting and news persuasion suggest that articles could shape readers' first-order economic perceptions (Kinder and Kiewiet, 1981; Hetherington, 1996; Garz and Martin, 2021), disconnect signaling predicts substantial relative effects of news on readers' perceptions of elite beliefs and comments on readers' perceptions of the beliefs of ordinary citizens.

Figure 5: Treatment Effects on Economic First- and Second-Order Beliefs



Notes: Treatment effects of positive article (blue) and negative comments (red) on first- and second-order economic perceptions, estimated in a pooled OLS model with preregistered covariate adjustment. Baseline condition: negative article, neutral comments. Article effect estimates are pooled across comment conditions and vice versa for simplicity (regression coefficients in Table A14). Unpooled estimates that allow for interaction effects between comment and article tone are substantively similar (Table A16; Figure A13). Scales are untransformed Likert scales (one to five points); the standard deviation of all outcomes is close enough to 1 that standardized effects are substantively equivalent. Error bars = 95% CI.

Figure 5 shows the average treatment effects of article and comment tone on first- and second-order beliefs about the economy (see Table A14 for raw regression coefficients, and Table A16/Figure A13 for substantively similar results from a model that includes the interaction of comment and article tone). Higher values indicate more optimistic economic views — or more optimistic views attributed to media, experts, politicians, or ordinary citizens. Consistent with theories of news persuasion, exposure to the positive article (compared to the negative article) increases both first-order economic perceptions and beliefs about how citizens view the economy. However, as predicted by disconnect signaling, the positive article exposure has much larger effects on elite-oriented second-order beliefs. In other words, news articles shape the way respondents believe journalists, experts, and politicians view economic conditions. The effect on politician second-order beliefs is particularly striking because politicians are not mentioned directly in either stimulus.¹²

The results also show that exposure to negative user comments (compared to neutral comments) decreases both economic perceptions and beliefs about what ordinary citizens think about the economy. These effects are as strong as (or stronger than) the effects of article tone — note the comment comparison baseline is weaker because negative comments are judged against neutral comments, while negative articles are judged against positive ones. When negative comments are paired with positive articles, the positive article’s effect on economic perceptions is muted to the point of losing significance (illustrated directly by Figure A13). Comments substantially offset, and may even overwhelm institutional information signals. Together, these results lend support for the first steps of the causal chain: articles shift what readers believe elites think, while comments shift readers’ perception of public experience.

¹²The question order of second-order belief referents was randomized between citizens, media, politicians, and experts. This helps to rule out the alternative explanation that priming drives this effect — respondents are more likely to rate politicians as feeling more positive about the economy compared to citizens regardless of question order.

5.2 Article Backlash

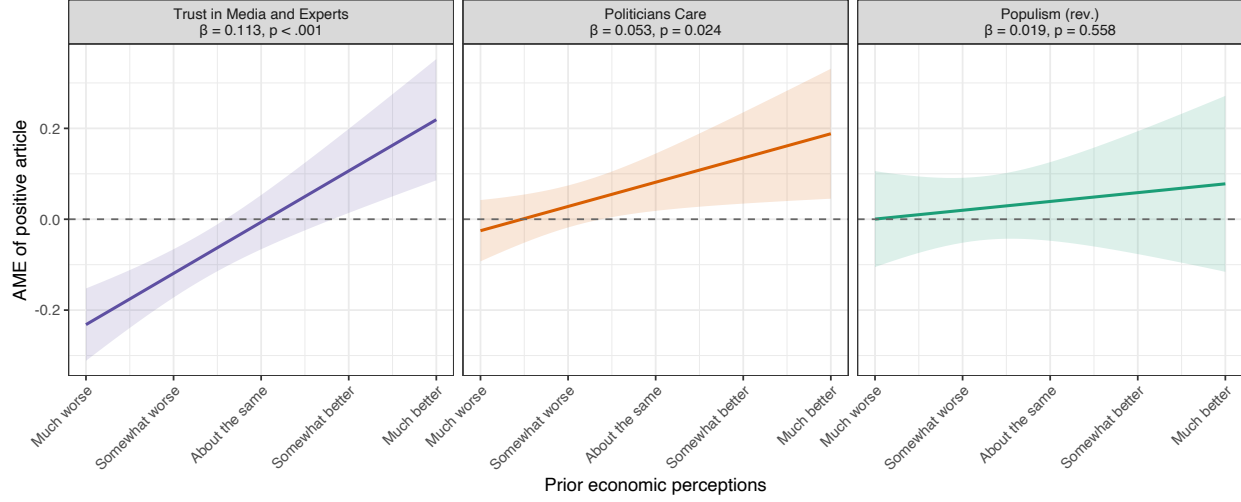
Next, I turn to the first pathway through which article signals of elite beliefs could lead to disconnect perceptions: through respondent priors about the economy. The article backlash hypothesis (H1) predicts that positive economic news increases disconnect perceptions for economically dissatisfied respondents — while decreasing them for economically satisfied respondents. To test this hypothesis, I regress each measure of disconnect (Y_i) — trust in media and experts, the “politicians care” index, and reversed people-centric populism — on an indicator for positive article exposure (PA) interacted with pre-treatment economic perceptions (EP; higher = more economically satisfied), with negative comment tone (NC) included as a control.¹³

$$Y_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{PA}_i + \beta_2 \text{EP}_i + \beta_3 \text{PA}_i \times \text{EP}_i + \beta_4 \text{NC}_i + \delta X_i + \epsilon_i$$

$\beta_3 > 0$ confirms the hypothesis. Figure 6 presents average marginal effects of the positive article across the distribution of pre-treatment economic perceptions (this distribution skews toward negative economic perceptions; full distribution illustration in Figure A11).

¹³My preregistered primary specification compares article tone effects within the neutral comments arm for maximally clean identification. However, the pooled estimates, preregistered as an alternative specification, increase precision with no substantive differences. Additionally, as discussed in the observational data, negative comments are the ecological standard. The formal test of whether comment tone interacts with article tone shows a null result, suggesting that pooling adds little confounding. See Appendix D for full robustness checks (including a specification that relaxes the linearity assumption of the moderation relationship) and the preregistered specification results.

Figure 6: H1: Effect of Positive Economic News by Prior Economic Satisfaction



Notes: Average marginal effect of positive economic article (compared to negative article) across the prior economic satisfaction distribution, estimated using a linear specification and preregistered covariate adjustment. Shading = 95% CI. Each outcome is a different facet of perceptions of disconnect, ordered from most proximal (trust in media and experts) to least proximal (populist attitudes).

The results for trust in media and experts clearly validate the theoretical predictions. Pre-treatment economic perceptions moderate the effects of reading the positive article on trust in media and experts, increasing it for the most economically satisfied (AME = 0.2), while decreasing it for the most dissatisfied (AME = -0.2); the interaction coefficient is substantively and statistically significant ($\beta_3 = 0.11, p < .001$). This index effect is driven both by declines in trust in experts and in national news organizations (Appendix D.4).

The results for the politicians care index are also consistent with the disconnect signaling theory. The interaction coefficient is significant ($\beta_3 = 0.06, p < .02$); positive article exposure increases perceptions that politicians care more for economically satisfied respondents than dissatisfied. While Figure 6 suggests that the article backlash effect is somewhat muted, additional analysis suggests that this could be the result of floor attenuation. The median politicians care index score for the most economically dissatisfied respondents in the baseline condition (negative news, neutral comments) is 1 out of 12 scale points (compared to 8 points for the most economically satisfied group; see Figure A12).

There is no detectable effect on people-centric populist attitudes, although the interaction

coefficient is directionally consistent. While conflicting news causes changes in institutional trust, these signaling effects do not appear to translate into preferences for people-centric populist attitudes within the timeframe of a single exposure.

Several additional analyses clarify the mechanism and scope of the effects. Perhaps most strikingly, partisanship plays a limited moderating role. Theories of partisan-motivated reasoning lead to the strong expectation that Democrats under the Trump presidency would distrust positive economic news, and vice versa. However, analysis in Appendix C.6 shows that prior-conflicting economic news decreases trust in media and experts and the politicians care index equally for both Democrat and Republican respondents. An instrumental-variables analysis further supports the proposed second-order belief mechanism. Among economically dissatisfied respondents, each unit increase in perceived elite economic optimism induced by positive article exposure reduces trust in media and experts by 0.28 SD; among those with neutral or positive priors, the CACE is indistinguishable from zero (Appendix C.4). Disaggregating by topic, the jobs article slightly attenuates the coefficients, consistent with its weaker perceived positivity and smaller effects on elite second-order beliefs (Appendix C.5). Exploratory analyses also find little evidence of moderation by household income or news interest (Appendix C.7).

To contextualize the effects documented here, I examine Ladd (2012)’s landmark study that argues elite influence causes declines in media trust using a survey experiment featuring attacks on the press from both Republican and Democratic politicians. In this study, the average effect of elite criticism on measures of media trust is about 0.16 standard deviations, with heterogeneity by partisanship and education; the effect of criticism by respondents’ copartisan elites is larger, at 0.26 standard deviations.¹⁴ This is roughly equivalent in magnitude to the effect I show of exposure to a positive economic news article for respondents

¹⁴Ladd (2012)’s original work presents results separately by partisan group and in unstandardized units. I re-analyze the data to provide comparable effects — see Table A26. Of course, apples-to-apples comparison is difficult because Ladd measures a different treatment, has different theoretical predictions, and uses a feeling thermometer scale rather than a direct measure of trust. However, the comparison provides a rough contextualization of the effects documented here.

with negative economic priors ($d = -0.36$ for the most negative prior group based on the primary article backlash specification, $d = -0.16$ for respondents with any negative priors; see Table A27). This equivalence is striking not only because elite criticism is one of the primary theoretical explanations for declines in media trust but also because the treatment (a direct attack on the press) is substantively stronger than the mere presentation of an article containing economic information.

5.3 Comment Mismatch

Next, I investigate the second pathway through which news signals of elite beliefs could drive disconnect outcomes: through the sociotropic effect of negative user comments. The preceding analysis shows that negative user comments cause readers to perceive the economy more negatively; the comment mismatch hypothesis (H2) thus predicts that these negative comments increase disconnect attitudes when paired with positive articles compared to when paired with negative articles.¹⁵

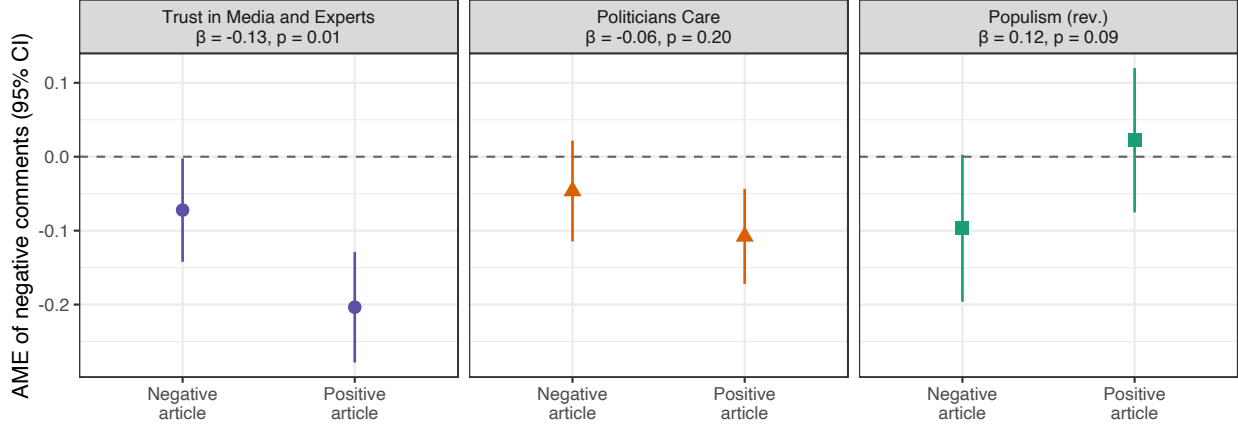
I test this hypothesis by estimating the following model:

$$Y_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{PA}_i + \beta_2 \text{NC}_i + \beta_3 \text{PA}_i \times \text{NC}_i + \delta X_i + \epsilon_i$$

The interaction coefficient $\beta_3 < 0$ confirms the hypothesis. Figure 7 presents the average marginal effect of negative comments (vs. neutral) at each level of article tone for each outcome; the difference between the two points in each panel is the interaction coefficient $\hat{\beta}_3$.

¹⁵A statistically equivalent interpretation is that the positive article increases disconnect more when accompanied by negative comments compared to neutral comments. One can interpret this as the negative comments allowing the positive article backlash to operate agnostic to the economic prior of the reader; user commentary replaces the prior in creating a counterpoint for article backlash.

Figure 7: H2: Comment Effects By Article Stance



Notes: Average marginal effect of negative comments (vs. neutral) on each outcome, estimated separately in positive- and negative-article contexts. Each panel reports $\hat{\beta}_3$, the interaction coefficient (positive article $\times$ negative comment): the gap between the two points within a panel equals $\hat{\beta}_3$, so a negative value indicates that the negative-comment effect is more negative when paired with a positive rather than negative article. Error bars = 95% CI.

The results show that negative comments (compared to neutral comments) substantively decrease trust in media and experts when paired with a positive article, but have little effect when paired with a negative article. This difference is statistically significant ($\beta_3 = -0.13$, $p < .05$); the mismatch between negative comment and positive article tone drives reductions in trust. Unlike the article backlash effect, this comment mismatch effect is concentrated in trust in experts rather than generalized media trust, which shows no significant interaction (Appendix D.4). Comment mismatch appears to have no effect on the “politicians care” index or populist attitudes: β_3 cannot be distinguished from zero, although the result for the politicians care index is directionally consistent.¹⁶ Additional analyses show robustness at the item level and across a variety of alternative specifications (Appendix D).

The main theoretical argument for the comment mismatch effect operates through *learning*: negative comments inform readers of public dissatisfaction, while the positive article

¹⁶I also estimate a not-quite-significant *positive* effect of the mismatch on people-centric attitudes ($\beta_3 = 0.12$, $p < 0.1$). One interpretation is noise; scale reliability of the populism index compared to other constructs is poor ($\alpha = 0.55$ in pilot data) and covariate $R^2 = 0.27$ is low, increasing variance and reducing precision relative to the other outcome measures. Another interpretation is that this is driven by negative comments decreasing people-centric populism for the economically satisfied. Appendix Figure A14 also offers a basis for this interpretation, although it is necessarily speculative given the lack of statistical power.

signals elite optimism, ultimately creating disconnect perceptions. However, an alternative priming explanation also predicts the same effect: negative comments could amplify disconnect perceptions for the economically dissatisfied while having no effect for the economically satisfied, leading to a substantive aggregate effect that masks heterogeneity. The distinction has both interpretive and normative stakes. If learning drives the effect, comments make disconnect salient to readers regardless of their prior economic views, potentially extending the reach of disconnect signaling beyond those with negative personal economic experiences. If priming drives the effect, comments selectively amplify skepticism among the economically dissatisfied, concentrating disconnect signaling rather than broadening it.

To distinguish these sub-mechanisms, I examine to what extent the comment mismatch effect on trust in media and experts varies by pre-treatment economic satisfaction using a triple interaction specification ($PA \times NC \times EP$).¹⁷ The triple interaction coefficient is near-zero and not statistically significant ($\beta = -0.01, p = 0.8$, Table A19; see Figure A14 for plots of the negative comment AME over the distribution of pre-treatment economic perceptions separately for each article condition). These results suggest that any priming effects among dissatisfied respondents are roughly offset by satisfied respondents learning from comments, producing no detectable net effect.¹⁸ Heterogeneity analysis of treatment effects on second-order belief outcomes further supports the dual-mechanism interpretation: negative comments shift positive-prior holders' perceptions of citizen economic views downward, while positive articles shift negative-prior holders' perceptions of elite economic views upward. Moreover, both of these effects are magnified in the mismatch condition (Appendix C.3).

The operation of the learning channel has substantive implications. Comments do not merely amplify preexisting discontent — they generate new disconnect perceptions. Economically satisfied readers who encounter negative comments update their beliefs about how ordinary citizens view the economy, and this updated perception of public dissatisfaction is

¹⁷This analysis was preregistered as RQ1. The minimum detectable effect for this test is approximately 0.3 SD per 1 pre-treatment economic perception scale point.

¹⁸This null interpretation was preregistered.

sufficient to erode trust in conflicting institutional coverage. Comments expand the scope of the article backlash mechanism beyond the economically aggrieved to anyone exposed to conflicting audience signals.

6 Conclusion

I find that exposure to economic news that conflicts with readers’ economic perceptions causes elites to appear out of touch. Moreover, online news comments exacerbate this dynamic; alternative economic narratives from ordinary citizens that clash with institutional accounts cause further declines in trust in media and experts. This effect appears to be mediated via second-order beliefs: disconnect perceptions are a consequence of a clash between readers’ perceptions and the beliefs of elites signaled by news articles. Curiously, partisanship plays little role in moderating these effects.

The results show that online comments can substantially alter the way audiences interpret news, complicating accounts where institutional signals dominate information processing. Comments, rather than news articles, most affected experimental participants’ beliefs about how ordinary citizens viewed economic conditions. Readers appear to integrate comment signals as legible public testimony, rather than discounting them in the presence of conflicting authoritative news. These effects have implications for important political attitudes; mismatch between comments and news articles erodes trust in media and experts independently of economic priors. This extends the small but growing literature on the political effects of user comments from toxicity and incivility (Anderson et al., 2018) and informational effects (Cao, Xu, and Yang, 2023; Lee, Jang, and Chung, 2021; Anspach and Carlson, 2020) to judgments of elite credibility inferred from comment-driven public consensus. Moreover, while this study focuses on news comments, the theory potentially generalizes to other forms of social media-enabled commentary, from comments beyond YouTube and Reddit to user-generated content such as TikTok reaction videos.

The findings suggest that new models of how voters form economic perceptions may be needed in the contemporary era of institutional distrust and the high-choice, networked media environment. The unique uncertainty of the “vibecession” period saw news coverage follow positive macroeconomic indicators while consumer sentiment remained starkly negative. The experimental results suggest negativity in online news comments may have not only been a reflection of consumer sentiment but could also plausibly have contributed to the persistence of such negative economic perceptions. This perspective contributes to a small but growing literature on “macro-economic perceptions,” where what citizens value most is the economic condition of “people like them” (Ansolabehere, Meredith, and Snowberg, 2014; Nagler, Zilinsky, and Linn, 2022). Voters may remain sociotropic — but instead of relying on societal reports of economic conditions from news media, they construct their inferences about the economic experiences of the public from user commentary online.

The broader implications of disconnect signaling are far-reaching. The loss of trust in knowledge institutions can lead to greater susceptibility to misinformation, reduced compliance with expert guidance on issues such as public health and climate, and the erosion of a shared factual basis for democratic deliberation (Ognyanova et al., 2020; Sturgis, Brunton-Smith, and Jackson, 2021). The growing gap between elite narratives and ordinary citizens’ experiences may also contribute to the rise in populist and affordability-oriented politics in the United States (Silva and Wratil, 2023). These shifts may become increasingly consequential as economic gains continue to concentrate, biasing economic coverage toward top income deciles (Jacobs et al., 2021) — a trend that will only be further amplified by the rapid development of artificial intelligence. Journalists, economists, and politicians may need to reconsider whether and how macroeconomic indicators reliably capture and reflect citizens’ economic experiences.

The present study has important limitations that suggest exciting avenues for future research. While I focus on economic news, disconnect signaling may also travel to issue contexts that feature conflict between aggregate reporting and reader experience such as

immigration, vaccines, and climate change. Future research could also establish further scope conditions around the targets of disconnect signaling: to what extent perceptions of disconnect extend beyond media and experts to political, economic, and other cultural elites. Finally, the continued evolution of the information environment raises important additional questions. As Americans increasingly turn away from mainstream news, semi-professional content creators and AI-mediated information consumption blur the boundaries between institutional authority and public voices. Disconnect signaling may represent a vulnerability of communication increasingly shaped by audience participation and algorithmic mediation.

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Online Appendix

Out of Touch

Sylvan Zheng

Appendices

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A Economic News and Comments: Additional Details and Analysis

A.1 Data Collection and Labeling Details

All three observational corpora — mainstream news, Reddit, and YouTube — were built using the same general workflow. First, a recall-oriented keyword filter (Table A1 lists the filter used for each corpus) identified candidate economic-news content. Second, a classifier (usually LLM based, though see below for details) determined whether or not candidate-content was actually about US economic news, as the first stage dictionary method permitted many false-positives where economic keywords were used in non-economic or international economic contexts. Only classifier-confirmed items were retained for the final analytic sample.

Mainstream news. Candidate economic news articles from the *New York Times*, *Washington Post*, *Los Angeles Times*, *Wall Street Journal*, and *Chicago Tribune* were retrieved from ProQuest TDM Studio, 2008–2025, using a subject-keyword search (Table A1). Because ProQuest TDM Studio’s secure research environment does not permit batch API calls to LLM providers, `gpt-4o-mini` was used to label about one-quarter (N=42,000) of the keyword matched articles. These labels were evaluated against a hand-coded set with 98% accuracy (117/120). Then, these labels were used to train a lighter-weight classifier that could run efficiently within ProQuest’s environment — a logistic regression on sentence-transformer embeddings (`all-MiniLM-L6-v2`) — which achieved F1= 0.87 on an 80/20 train/test split using the LLM labels as ground truth. This process yielded the final analytic sample of mainstream economic news articles (N=166,000). Article-level economic tone was scored using the Shapiro, Sudhof, and Wilson (2022) economic sentiment lexicon, developed specifically for economic and financial journalism.

Reddit. Reddit posts and comments were drawn from the Pushshift Reddit dataset (Baumgartner et al., 2020), covering two subreddits: `r/news` (the highest-traffic general-news subreddit) and `r/Conservative` (included to offset Reddit’s documented liberal skew). Candidate economic-news posts were identified via a full-text search over each post’s title and body using a stemmed keyword list (Table A1), yielding approximately 490,000 keyword-matched posts (2008–2024). A stratified random 10% sample (balanced across year, subreddit, and comment-count decile) was drawn from this pool for computational tractability and submitted to a `gpt-4.1-mini` classifier to identify US economic news. The top 16 comments on each retained post, ranked by score — a comment’s net upvotes, the metric Reddit itself uses to order comments within a thread, so the highest-scored comments approximate those most visible to readers — were then collected, yielding the final analytic sample of 21,314 posts and 219,299 comments reported in the main text. Each comment was assigned a stance label toward the US economy using `gpt-4.1-mini`, using the post title and (where applicable) parent comment as context. The classifier’s accuracy was validated against 260 hand-coded comments drawn from this sample, achieving 90% accuracy and macro-F1. Each economic news post was also assigned an article-level stance toward the US economy (−1/0/+1) using the same model and rubric as the comment-level classifier; this post-level stance identifies

the positive-news posts used in Appendix Figure A4.

YouTube. YouTube data cover the official channels of five outlets — CNN, CNBC, BBC News, Fox News, and MS NOW (formerly MSNBC, renamed in 2024) — from 2016 through 2025. Video IDs and full metadata (title, description, publish date, view count) were scraped directly from each channel’s upload history using `yt-dlp`, yielding 307,191 videos across the five channels. These were filtered to 41,121 videos classified as US economic news using the same keyword-then-LLM classification workflow as Reddit (Table A1 lists the YouTube keyword filter). Comments were collected for each video using the `youtube-comment-downloader` public scraper (Bouman, 2024), retrieving up to 10 top comments per video ranked by vote count, yielding the final sample of 15,004 videos and 139,669 comments. Each comment was assigned a stance label using the same `gpt-4.1-mini` prompt and coding rubric applied to Reddit comments, adapted only in that the video’s title, description, and channel (rather than an article or parent comment) are included in the comment context.

Mainstream news	Reddit	YouTube
econom*, gdp, recession, inflation, employment, unemployment, job*, labor, wages, income	econom, work, job, employ, lay-off, fired, hiring, wage, salary, earnings, income, price, inflation, rate, afford, cost, recession, depression, gdp, domestic, product, growth, slowdown, downturn, deficit, debt, spending, budget, tax, tariff, trade, stock, market, nasdaq, dow	economy, economic, inflation, jobs report, unemploy(ment/ed), fed, federal reserve, interest rate, rate hike/cut/hold, stock market, gdp, recession, wall street, consumer spending, housing market, home prices, mortgage, gas prices, oil prices, grocery, cost of living, afford/affordable/affordability, paycheck, wages, minimum wage, student loan/debt, layoffs, jobless, hiring, job cuts/market, labor market, labor strike, workers on strike, union strike, walkout, union, tariff, trade deal/war, supply chain, shortage, debt, bankruptcy, eviction, rent, credit card, tax/taxes/taxation, budget, spending bill, social security, medicare, central bank, market/markets, dow, s&p, nasdaq, earnings report, billionaire, wealth gap, poverty, food stamps, ceo, profits, prices (plural only)

Table A1: Keyword filters used to identify candidate economic-news content, by corpus. Mainstream news: ProQuest subject-field search, stemmed via trailing *. Reddit: PostgreSQL full-text search over stemmed lexemes. YouTube: case-insensitive regex over video titles/descriptions; slashes indicate alternatives matched by a single regex term.

Relevance-classification prompts. The keyword-matched candidate pool in each corpus was passed to an LLM classifier that determined whether the item was actually about the US economy. The mainstream-news and Reddit prompts are nearly identical, differing only in whether the input is an “article” or “post,” in whether a short keyword-heuristics section and an explanation field are included, and in model (*gpt-4o-mini* for news, *gpt-4.1-mini* for Reddit); their shared core is condensed below. The YouTube prompt serves the same purpose but is phrased around videos and adds an explicit foreign-country exclusion; it is condensed separately.

Mainstream news (gpt-4o-mini) / Reddit (gpt-4.1-mini):

Classify each [article/post] as related to the U.S. economy or not, based on its [title and lede/title and URL].

Definition: an [article/post] is about the U.S. economy if its main focus is on overall economic conditions, economic performance, or key economic indicators in the United States, including economic growth or decline, employment or labor-market conditions, inflation/prices/cost of living, consumer or business activity, and fiscal or monetary policy discussed in terms of economic impact. It should primarily concern the U.S., not other countries, and should focus on economic matters rather than merely mention them in passing.

Exclusions: do not classify as economy-related if the [article/post] is mainly about foreign economies or international trade without focusing on U.S. effects; if “economy” or related words appear only in passing or as a metaphor (e.g., “the baseball economy”); or if the main topic is a non-economic domain (politics, education, sports, health, culture) unless it centers on the economic consequences of those issues.

Output Format: JSON with a YES/NO classification. *[Mainstream-news version only: preceded by a short heuristics section listing headline/first-paragraph keyword cues (“economy,” “recession,” “inflation,” “layoff,” etc.), and additionally requests a 1-2 sentence explanation.]*

YouTube (gpt-4.1-mini):

Given a video’s title, description, and channel, determine whether the video is substantively about the US economy specifically -- its overall conditions, policy, or specific US economic indicators (e.g. the Federal Reserve, US inflation, US jobs/unemployment, the US stock market, tariffs, the housing market, wages, consumer spending).

Classify as NOT_US_ECONOMY when the video is instead about a different country’s or region’s economy, global/general economic concepts not centered on the US, or something that merely uses economic-sounding words without being about economic conditions (e.g. a game show, a non-economic “job” story). The video need not be exclusively about

the US economy -- one that substantively covers US conditions while also referencing other countries for comparison is still US_ECONOMY.

Output Format: JSON with a one-sentence Reasoning and a USEconomy classification (US_ECONOMY/NOT_US_ECONOMY).

Comment stance-classification prompt. The exact prompt used with gpt-4.1-mini to assign a stance label (POSITIVE/NEGATIVE/OTHER) toward the US economy to each Reddit and YouTube comment is reproduced verbatim below.

Given a user comment, evaluate its stance toward the current US economy.

User comments are in response to news articles and to parent comments. The title and url of the news article will be provided, as will the text of the parent comment, if any.

Definition Stance toward the current US economy is defined as whether the commenter expresses a clear positive or negative evaluation of overall current or recent U.S. economic conditions (e.g., national growth, inflation, employment, prices, or general economic well-being). POSITIVE comments must contain a claim that the overall U.S. economy is doing well. Examples include:

mentions of positive national economic indicators

personal or local experiences used as evidence of general economic improvement. The claim may be implicit when the comment is being used to respond to a parent comment or post title.

direct descriptions of the economy as good, strong, healthy, improving, etc.

NEGATIVE comments must contain a claim that the overall U.S. economy is doing poorly. Examples include:

mentions of negative national economic indicators

personal or local hardships used as evidence of national economic decline. The claim may be implicit when the comment is being used to respond to a parent comment or post title.

direct descriptions of the economy as bad, weak, unhealthy, worsening, etc.

OTHER applies when no explicit claim about overall U.S. economic conditions is made. This includes:

commentary about politics, ideology, media narratives, hypocrisy, corruption, or culture

sarcasm that mocks political actors or common talking points without asserting economic conditions

discussions of individual policies (taxes, health care, minimum wage, ACA, job quality, inequality) unless the author directly generalizes them to national economic performance

local or personal anecdotes without an explicit national generalization

descriptive financial mechanics or market volatility without evaluation of overall economic conditions

comparisons involving other countries

historical claims without evaluating current conditions

Clarifications

Evaluative language about welfare, inequality, wealth distribution, or class conflict is OTHER unless the commenter explicitly states the U.S. economy overall is good or bad.

Sarcasm should be interpreted based on the underlying literal claim.

If the literal content does not explicitly evaluate current national economic conditions, label as OTHER.

Output Format

Respond using JSON with the following keys:

- Reasoning - Explain your reasoning
- Stance - a classification (POSITIVE/NEGATIVE/OTHER)

The YouTube version of this prompt is identical except that the input context fields are the video's title, description, and channel in place of the article title/url and parent comment.

A.2 News Tone by Outlet

Figure A1 replicates the main observational result disaggregated by outlet. The pattern of positive news tone during 2021–2025 despite depressed consumer sentiment holds across all five publications individually; no single outlet drives the aggregate result.

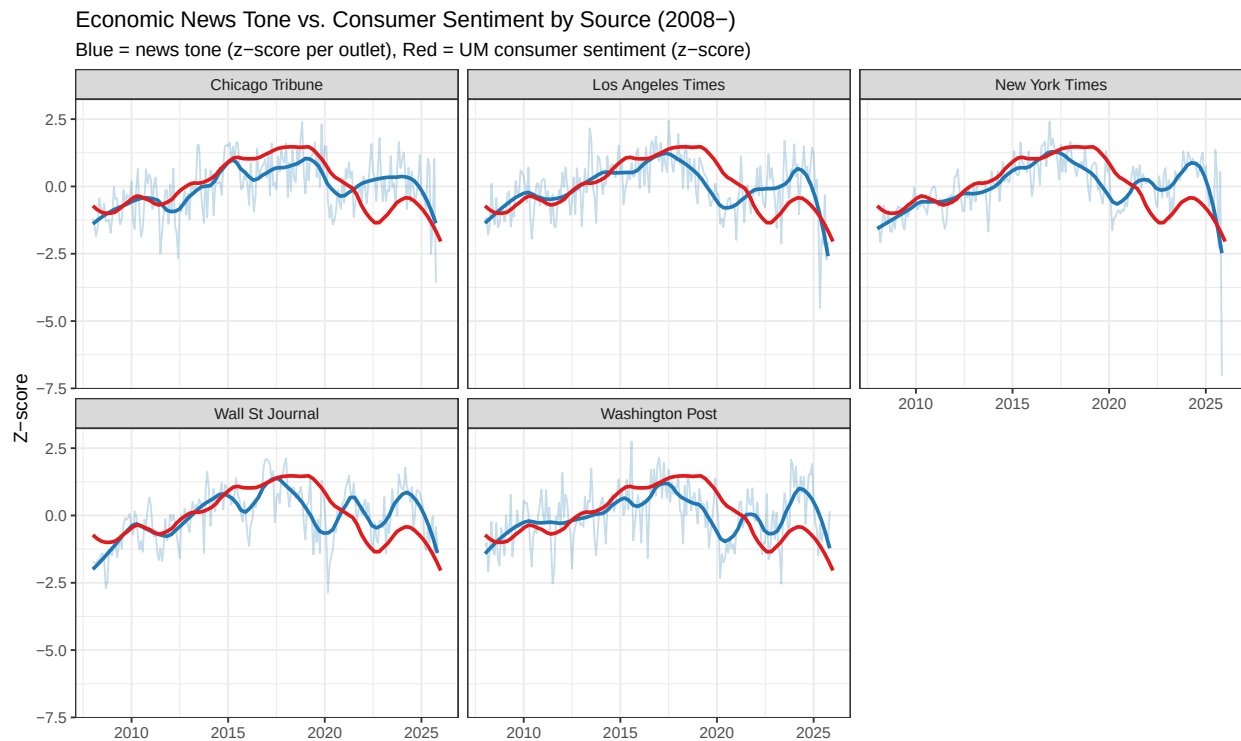


Figure A1: News tone vs. consumer sentiment by outlet, 2008–2025.

A.3 Macro Conditions Composite

The macro conditions series used in Figures 1 and 3 is constructed by regressing monthly news tone (Shapiro et al. score) on three macroeconomic indicators: the unemployment rate (BLS, seasonally adjusted), year-over-year CPI inflation (BLS, All Items), and monthly GDP growth (BBK monthly GDP index from the Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis). This regression yields data-driven weights that capture how strongly each indicator predicts news tone, rather than imposing equal weights.

Table A2 reports the regression coefficients. Column 1 presents raw coefficients; Column 2 presents standardized (z-scored) coefficients for comparability across indicators. Together, the three indicators explain a substantial share of the variance in monthly news tone.

Table A2: Consumer Sentiment and News Tone Regressed on Macroeconomic Indicators

Dependent Variables: Model:	Consumer Sentiment Index (1)	News Tone (2)
<i>Variables</i>		
Constant	107.2*** (2.872)	0.0296*** (0.0038)
Unemployment rate	-3.128*** (0.3659)	-0.0036*** (0.0005)
Inflation (YoY %)	-4.298*** (0.4079)	-0.0020*** (0.0005)
GDP growth (monthly %)	0.0104 (0.0938)	0.0003** (0.0001)
<i>Fit statistics</i>		
Observations	214	214
R ²	0.38574	0.22620
<i>IID standard-errors in parentheses</i>		
<i>Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1</i>		

A.4 Engagement Over Time

Figure A2 reports four measures of audience engagement with economic news commentary over time: mean votes per comment and mean number of comments per thread/video (Reddit vs. YouTube, top row), and — to net out YouTube’s own view growth — comments and comment votes scaled by view count (bottom row; Reddit has no view-count field, so no equivalent normalized measure is shown for it). The two top-row measures trend upward from their early-sample baselines into the 2021–2025 period on both platforms, though not perfectly monotonically. The two view-normalized YouTube measures rise as well, from 2016 through the 2021–2024 window before cooling somewhat in 2025–2026, indicating the volume growth is not purely an artifact of the videos themselves getting more views.

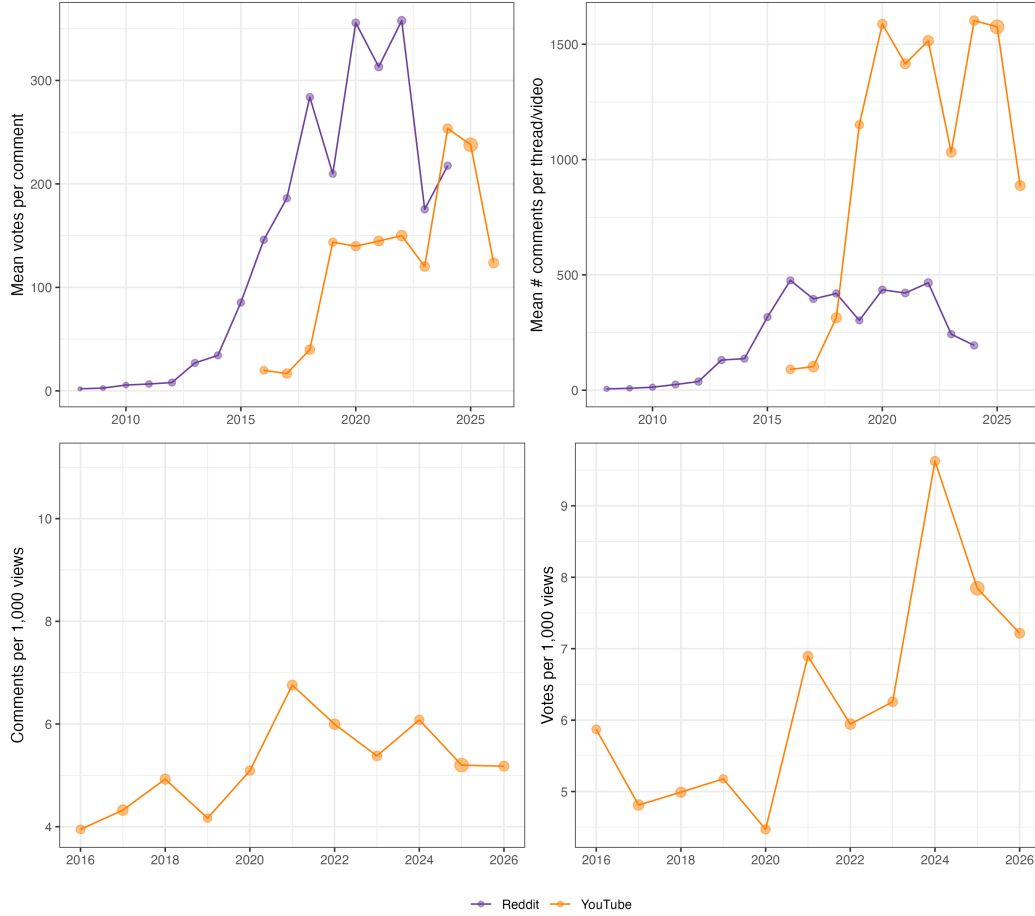


Figure A2: Engagement with economic news commentary over time, Reddit vs. YouTube.

Notes: Top row: mean votes per comment (left) and mean number of comments per thread/video (right), Reddit vs. YouTube, unnormalized. Bottom row: YouTube-only comment rate (comments per 1,000 views, left) and votes rate (votes per 1,000 views, right). Point size proportional to number of posts/videos/comments underlying each year.

A.5 Within-Post Comment Negativity

The main text and figures report mean comment tone over time; for additional context, the following figures characterize within-thread and channel comment tone dynamics. Figure A3 shows the percent of threads on both platforms where the majority of the top comments are negative, while Figure A4 shows the number of positive news article threads on Reddit which have more negative than positive comments.

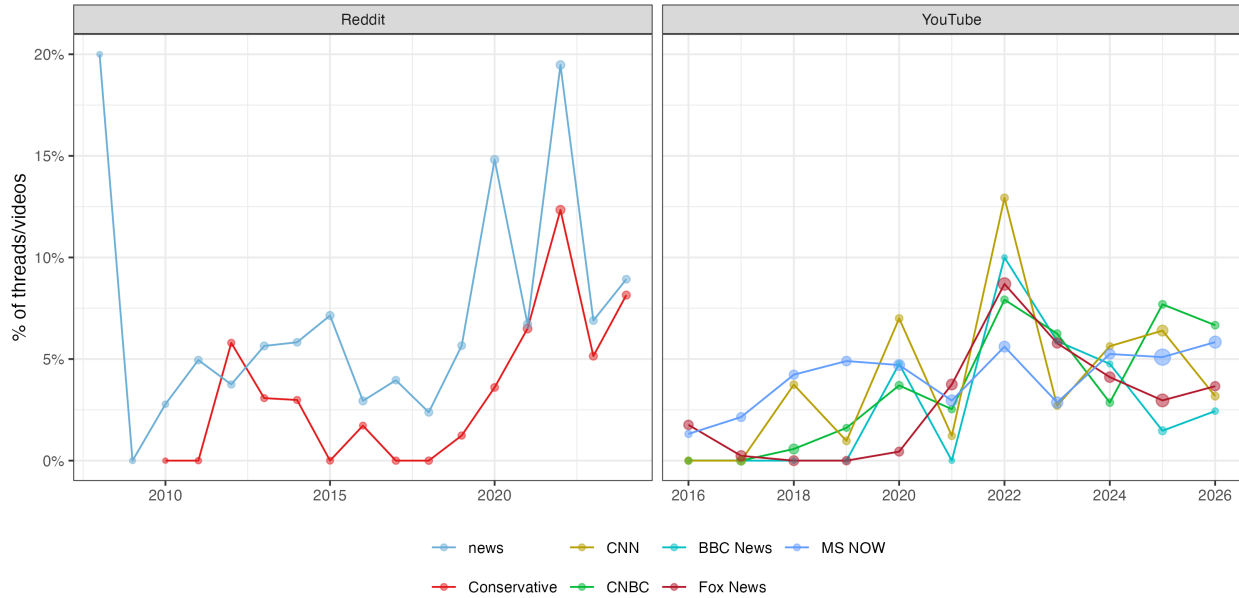


Figure A3: Share of Threads/Videos Where ≥ 3 of Top 4 Comments Are Negative

Notes: Percentage of economic news threads/videos where at least 3 of the top 4 top-level comments by popularity (Reddit: upvotes; YouTube: votes) express negative economic evaluations, by subreddit (left) and YouTube channel (right). Limited to threads/videos with at least 4 top-level comments. Point size proportional to number of threads/videos.

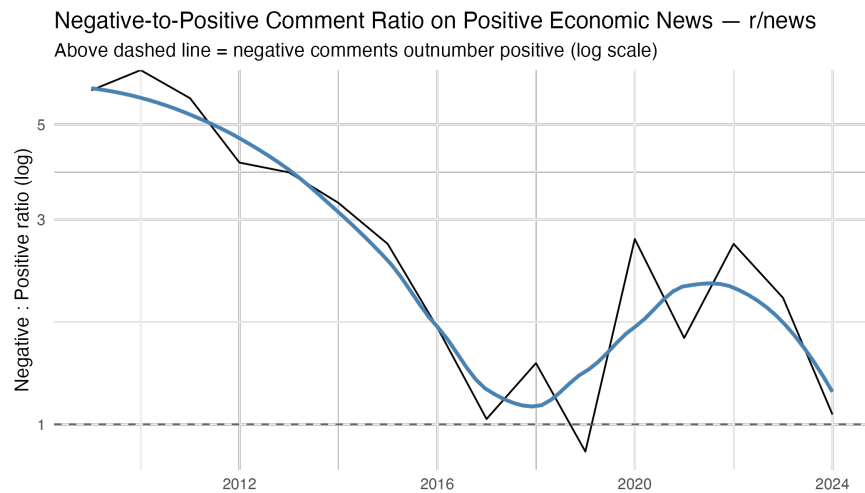


Figure A4: Ratio of positive to negative comments on /r/news, 2008–2025. Sample restricted to positive news articles.

A.6 Comment Tone by Channel and Subreddit

Figure A5 disaggregates the pooled Reddit/YouTube comparison in Figure 2 by individual subreddit and YouTube channel, faceted by platform. While the largest declines in com-

ment tone are in /r/Conservative and on Fox News, consistent with partisanship influencing economic expression online as Biden takes office in 2021, comment tone also substantively declines within the other subreddits and channels with the exception of MS NOW.

MS NOW is the main outlier revealed by this analysis; comment tone on economic MS NOW videos did not dramatically change over the 2016–2022 period. Given MS NOW’s liberal audience, negative economic sentiment during Trump’s term is likely an artifact of partisan expression. However, the fact that expressed sentiment did not dramatically change during Biden’s term and in fact continued to stay relatively negative is consistent with the overall descriptive findings of this paper. A brief qualitative analysis of the comment text supports this interpretation; while the majority of negative MS NOW comments focused on Trump and tariff policy during 2016–2020, during 2021–2024 the dominant topic shifted to inflation and prices consistent with the vibecession narrative.

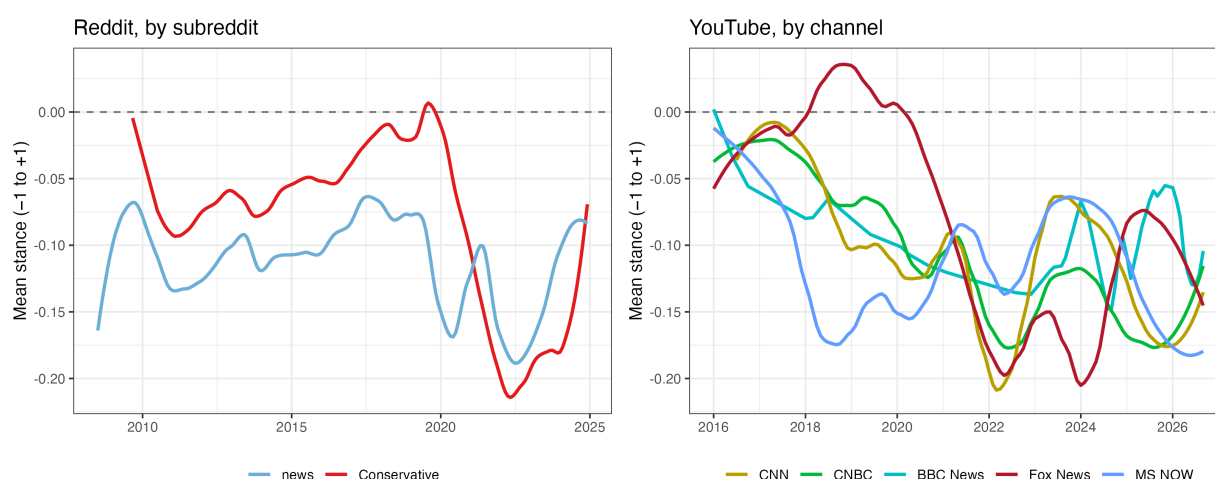


Figure A5: Mean comment stance on economic news, by subreddit (left) and YouTube channel (right).

Notes: Stance coded -1 (negative), 0 (neutral), $+1$ (positive) via GPT-4.1-mini (both platforms). Monthly means smoothed via LOESS with a common fixed 36-month bandwidth (see notes to Figure 2); raw monthly points omitted for legibility. Dashed line marks zero.

Figure A6 replicates Figure 3, disaggregating Reddit and YouTube by subreddit and channel. The figure shows similar results; comment tone on all subreddits and channels (even MS NOW) become more correlated with consumer sentiment over time and particularly starting in 2021.

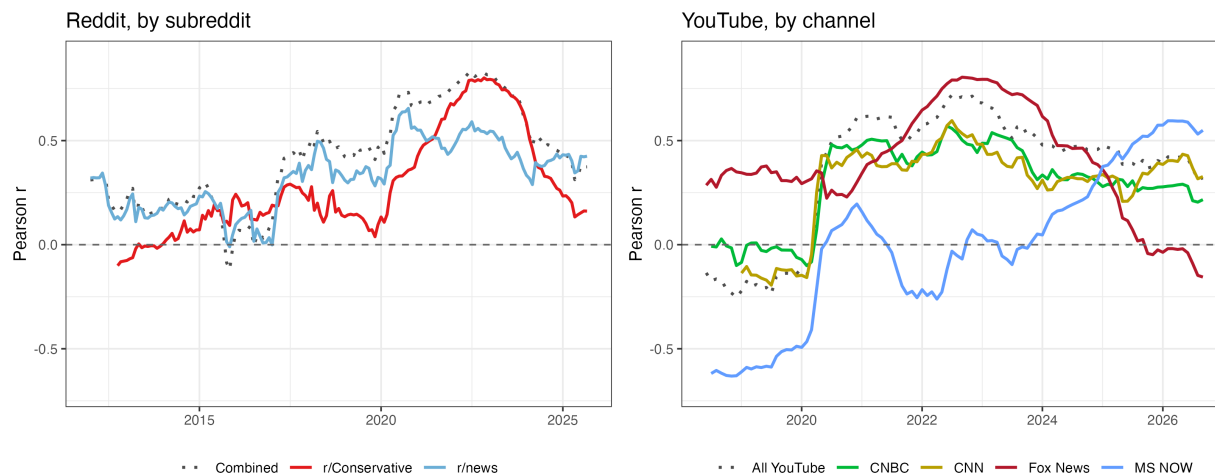


Figure A6: Rolling 48-month Pearson correlations with consumer sentiment (University of Michigan ICS), by subreddit (left) and YouTube channel (right). The dotted line in the right panel is the pooled YouTube series. Monthly channel means require at least 20 comments; BBC News excluded because of too-sparse data.

A.7 VAR and Granger Causality

This appendix presents a vector autoregression (VAR) analysis of a four-variable system relating monthly news tone to macroeconomic indicators.

A.7.1 Macroeconomic Indicators and News Tone

To test whether macroeconomic conditions causally precede news coverage tone — rather than merely co-moving with it — I estimate a vector autoregression jointly modeling monthly news tone and three macroeconomic indicators: the unemployment rate, year-over-year CPI inflation, and monthly GDP growth. The model is fit on the 2008–2025 period ($N = 214$ months), with lag order selected by AIC ($p = 4$).

Granger-causality tests reject the null that each macro indicator does not predict future news tone for unemployment ($F = 18.65$, $p < 0.001$) and GDP growth ($F = 20.75$, $p < 0.001$); the corresponding test for inflation is marginal ($F = 1.74$, $p = 0.054$). Figure A7 shows the impulse response of news tone to a one-standard-deviation shock in each macroeconomic indicator: news tone responds within four to six months and in the expected direction in each case.

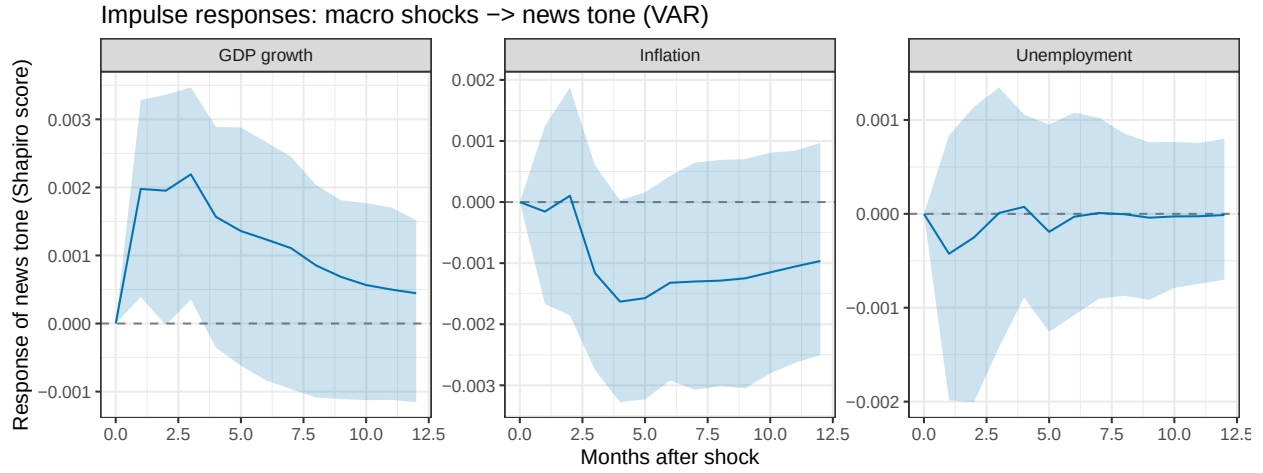


Figure A7: Impulse responses of news tone (Shapiro score) to one-standard-deviation shocks in each macroeconomic indicator over a twelve-month horizon. Shaded bands are 95% bootstrap confidence intervals.

Full coefficient estimates for the four-variable VAR are reported in Table A3.

Table A3: VAR coefficient estimates: news tone equation of the four-variable VAR in levels ($p = 4$). The other three equations (with unemployment, inflation, and GDP as dependent variables) are part of the joint system but omitted as they are not of substantive interest. Joint Granger F-tests at the bottom show that each macro variable's lags jointly predict news tone, even when individual lag coefficients are small.

	News tone _t
News tone _{t-1}	0.705*** (0.083)
Unemp. _{t-1}	0.001 (0.002)
Inflation _{t-1}	-0.002 (0.002)
GDP _{t-1}	0.001** (0.000)
News tone _{t-2}	-0.024 (0.099)
Unemp. _{t-2}	-0.004 (0.002)
Inflation _{t-2}	0.003 (0.004)
GDP _{t-2}	-0.001 (0.000)
News tone _{t-3}	-0.037 (0.098)
Unemp. _{t-3}	0.003 (0.003)
Inflation _{t-3}	-0.005 (0.004)
GDP _{t-3}	0.000 (0.000)
News tone _{t-4}	0.178* (0.081)
Unemp. _{t-4}	-0.000 (0.002)
Inflation _{t-4}	0.003 (0.002)
GDP _{t-4}	0.000 (0.000)
Constant	0.003 (0.004)
Granger F: Unemp. lags	18.65 (p = < 0.001)
Granger F: Inflation lags	1.74 (p = 0.054)
Granger F: GDP lags	20.75 (p = < 0.001)
Num.Obs.	210
R2	0.628

* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

B Experimental Details

B.1 Ethics

The design and conduct of this study conforms to the APSA Principles and Guidance for Human Subjects Research. The study was reviewed and approved by New York University’s Institutional Review Board (IRB-FY2026-10976). All participants provided informed consent at the first stage of the online survey and were informed that participation was voluntary. Compensation was set above prevailing market rates for online survey work, averaging approximately \$18 per hour. Participant identifiers from Prolific were stored separately from response data, replaced with anonymized study IDs in analysis files, and will not be shared in any public release; identifying information is held under secure data storage practices consistent with the IRB protocol to minimize risk of re-identification.

The participant pool is diverse along the dimensions most relevant to the study’s theoretical claims. Quota sampling on party identification (equal Democrat / Independent / Republican shares) and on education (equal college / non-college shares) was used in part to deliberately oversample respondents without a four-year degree relative to Prolific’s natural distribution, ensuring meaningful representation of a group that is often underrepresented in online convenience samples. No protected categories were used as inclusion or exclusion criteria beyond residence in the United States and adulthood.

The most plausible ethical concern is that the experimental stimuli could mislead participants about economic conditions; however, several features of the design substantially mitigate this concern. First, the stimuli were drawn from realistic economic reporting and audience commentary. The period in which the experiment was fielded was characterized by genuinely mixed and idiosyncratic economic signals, such that both the article and comment stimuli reflected ecologically valid components of the real-world information environment. Second, all participants were fully debriefed at the end of the survey: they were informed that the article and comments had been constructed as part of a randomized experiment and that the stimuli should not be taken as a comprehensive representation of current economic conditions. Third, a manual review of open-ended responses provided by participants suggested that participants generally welcomed the opportunity to register their views and frustrations about the economy. Taken together, the limited duration of exposure, the realism of the stimuli relative to the contemporaneous news environment, the post-experiment debriefing, and participants’ own reactions indicate that the design carried minimal risk of meaningful harm or sustained misinformation.

B.2 Stimuli

Articles. Two article stimuli were written for each tone condition, covering two economic subdomains: (1) general economic conditions (GDP, growth, consumer spending) and (2) the labor market (jobs, unemployment, wages). Positive articles emphasized optimistic aggregate indicators (e.g., strong job growth, GDP beating expectations); negative articles emphasized deteriorating conditions (e.g., job growth stalling, consumer confidence declining). All articles were matched on structure (lede, body, expert quote), approximate length, and reading level, and pretested for perceived positivity and realism. Positive articles scored

4.27–4.69 on a 5-point positivity scale; realism scores were 3.27–3.47 for both article types, with the jobs article rated slightly more realistic.

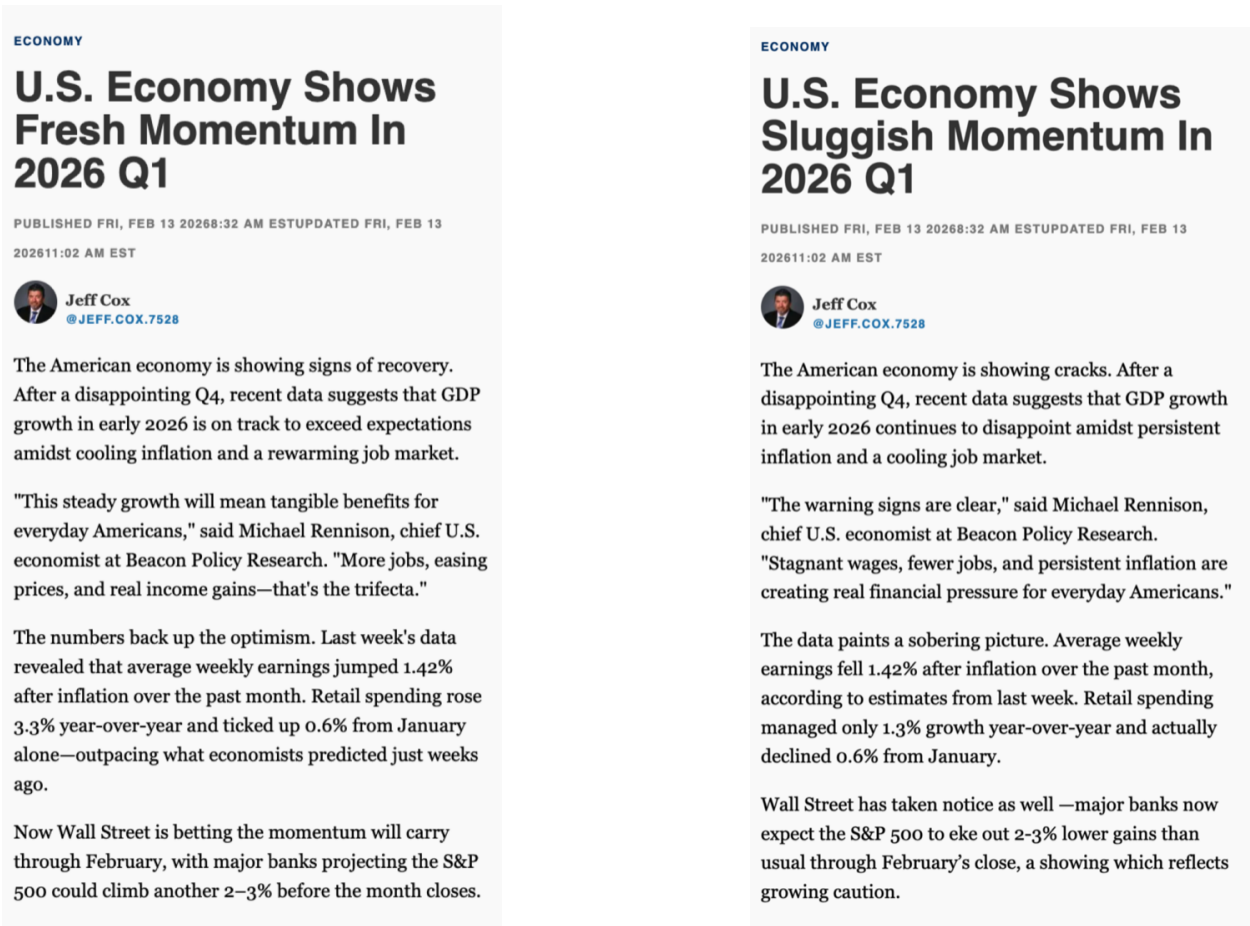


Figure A8: Article stimulus screenshots — general topic condition

ECONOMY

Job Growth Surges Past Expectations in January, Easing Labor Market Fears

PUBLISHED WED, FEB 25 2026 8:32 AM EST UPDATED WED, FEB 25 2026 11:02 AM EST



Jeff Cox
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Job growth was stronger than expected to start 2026, providing relief to concerns about the state of the U.S. labor market. The unemployment rate edged lower to 4.3%, below the forecast of 4.4%.

Nonfarm payrolls increased by 130,000 for January, well above the Dow Jones consensus estimate of 55,000, according to seasonally adjusted figures released last Wednesday. The total was also an improvement over December, which saw a gain of 48,000.

Markets rose following the news, with stock market futures ticking higher. Treasury yields also posted strong gains.

"It was a January job surge," said Heather Long, chief economist at Navy Federal Credit Union. "The surprisingly strong job gains suggest that the job market is stabilizing. That's an encouraging sign to start the year, especially for working and middle income families."

Job Growth Remains Sluggish in January, Falling Short of Recovery

PUBLISHED WED, FEB 25 2026 8:32 AM EST UPDATED WED, FEB 25 2026 11:02 AM EST



Jeff Cox
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Job growth disappointed at the start of 2026, offering little relief to workers who have struggled through a prolonged period of labor market weakness. The unemployment rate held steady at 4.4%, missing forecasts for improvement.

Nonfarm payrolls increased by only 130,000 for January, well below the Dow Jones consensus estimate of 185,000, according to seasonally adjusted figures released Wednesday. Several categories posted losses including federal government employment and financial activities.

Markets fell following the news, with stock market futures ticking lower. Treasury yields also posted weak gains.

"We've been hearing from workers that the job market is not working for them for some time," said Heather Long, chief economist at Navy Federal Credit Union. "The anecdotes are starting to align with the data."

Figure A9: Article stimulus screenshots — jobs topic condition

Comments. Comment stimuli were drawn from a pool of genuine Reddit comments on economic news posts and comments collected from participants in earlier pilot experiments, lightly edited for length and formatting. Negative comments expressed skepticism toward economic optimism, frustration with economic conditions, or distrust of institutional economic reporting (e.g., "These numbers don't reflect what I'm seeing at the grocery store"). Neutral comments were off-topic or expressed no clear economic valence. Comments were pre-tested for perceived tone and realism. Each condition displayed four comments beneath the article, matched for approximate length.

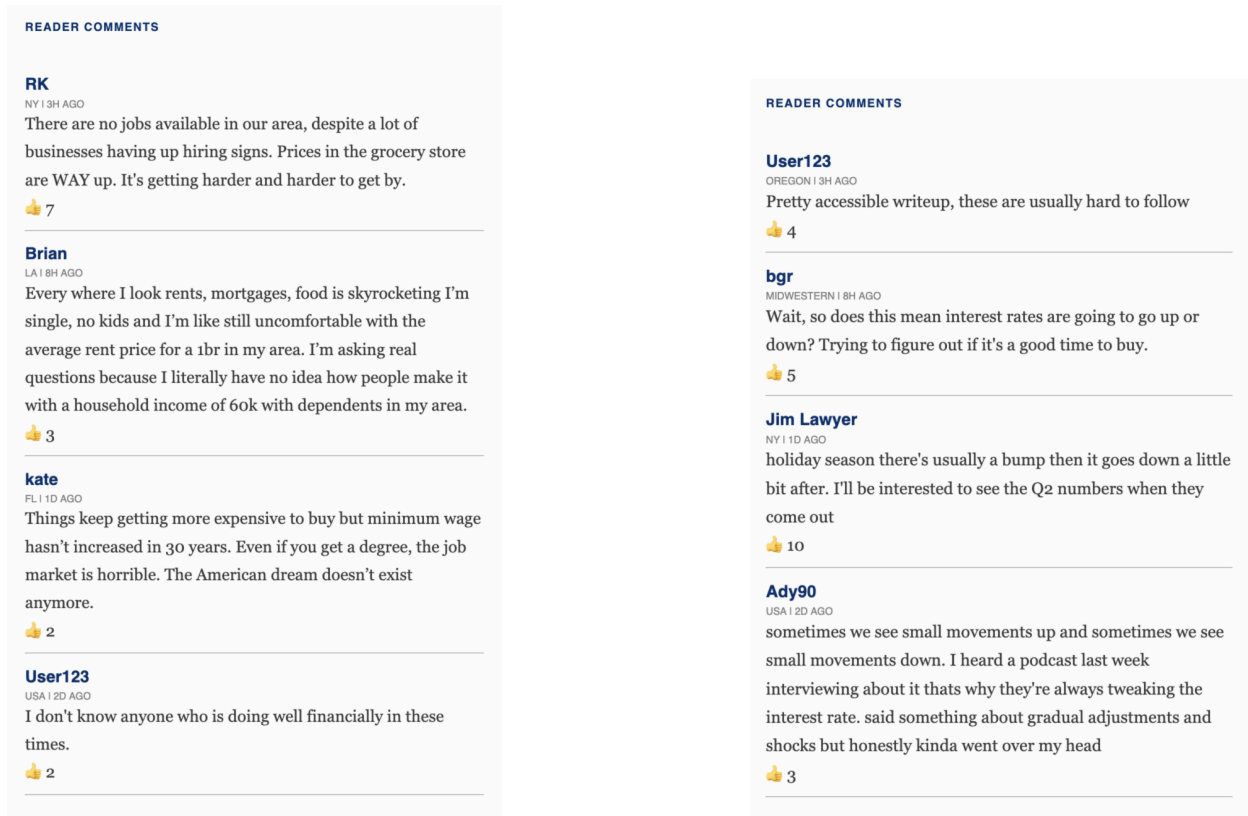


Figure A10: Comment stimulus screenshots.

B.3 Sample and Randomization

Participants ($N = 2,400$) were recruited via Prolific. To correct for Prolific’s demographic skew, participants were quota-sampled on two dimensions: party identification (equal three-way split: Democrat / Independent / Republican) and education (equal college / non-college split). Participants were block-randomized within strata defined by pre-treatment economic pessimism (*econ_pre*) to maximize statistical power for heterogeneous-effects analyses.

Participants were excluded for: (1) speeding (completing the survey in under 40% of median completion time — seven minutes), (2) failing attention checks, or (3) bot detection (honeypot items or inconsistent response patterns). After exclusions, $N = 2,249$ are retained for analysis.

B.4 Measures

Outcomes. Three outcome constructs are measured as standardized indices (higher = less populist, more trusting) on a 5-point agree/disagree scale (items marked † reverse-coded).

People-centric populism:

- “Politicians ought to be following the will of the people” (Akkerman, Mudde, and Zaslove, 2014; Bertsou and Caramani, 2022)

- “It’s important for a political leader to be like the people he or she represents” (Castanho Silva et al., 2020; Bertsou and Caramani, 2022)
- “Politics is a fight between the good people and the corrupt elite” (Akkerman, Mudde, and Zaslove, 2014)

Politicians care:

- “Public officials care about what people like me think” (ANES; Campbell, Gurin, and Miller 1954)
- “Politicians understand the economic reality I am living in” (SSRS Economic Attitudes Tracker)
- “The system is stacked against people like me” † (Oliver and Rahn, 2016)

Trust in media and experts:

- “When it comes to public policy, I’d rather place my trust in experts than the opinions of ordinary people” (Oliver and Rahn, 2016; Bertsou and Caramani, 2022)
- “Experts often claim to know what’s best, but they’re frequently out of touch with reality” †
- “The news media can be trusted to report the news fully, accurately, and fairly.” † (ANES)

Each index is the unweighted average of its component items after reverse-coding, standardized to mean 0, SD 1 in the full post-exclusion sample.

Economic Perceptions. The primary moderator *econ_pre* is a 5-point pre-treatment item: “Over the past year, would you say that the national economy has gotten better, stayed about the same, or gotten worse?” (Much Better to Much Worse). An alternative moderator *econ_identity* is based on Nagler, Zilinsky, and Linn (2022) and asks whether “Now thinking not of yourself personally, but thinking of people like you — how do you think people like you are doing financially right now?”

Covariates. Pre-treatment political attitudes (5 items, 5-point agree/disagree): “Politicians need to follow the will of the people”; “The system is stacked against people like me”; “Public officials care about what people like me think”; “The news media presents fair and accurate information”; “When it comes to public policy, I’d rather put my trust in experts than the opinions of ordinary people”. Additional covariates: *econ_identity*, party identification (5-point scale), news interest, education, and household income.

Manipulation checks. Post-treatment items measured perceived article tone (5-point), article trust (5-point), and second-order beliefs about how well media, experts, politicians, and citizens think the economy is doing (5-point, same anchors as *econ_pre*).

Table A4: Sample demographics and covariates (attention-passing sample)

Variable	Type	Mean	SD	Min	Median	Max
Age	Continuous	43.00	14.29	18	41	86
Household income (\$)	Continuous	64567.36	42180.96	10000	60000	150000
Education (years)	Continuous	14.67	2.43	8	14	20
Female	Binary (0/1)	0.55	0.50	0	1	1
White	Binary (0/1)	0.77	0.42	0	1	1
News interest	4-point scale	3.16	0.89	1	3	4
Economic perceptions (pre)	5-point scale	2.24	1.08	1	2	5
Democrat (party lean)	Binary (0/1)	0.48	0.50	0	0	1
Republican (party lean)	Binary (0/1)	0.39	0.49	0	0	1

B.5 Experimental Descriptives and Balance

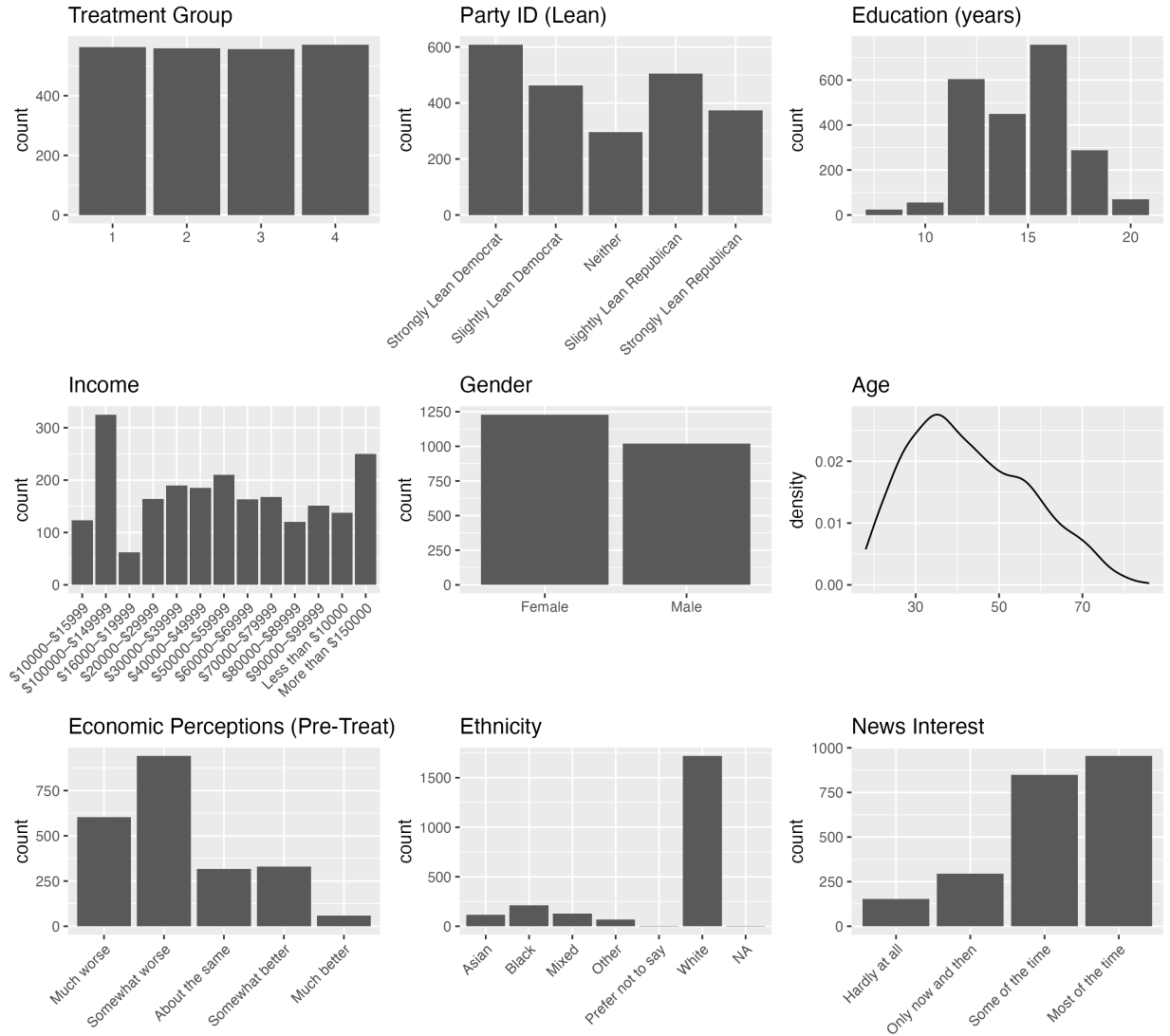


Table A5: Balance table; Max.Diff.Un shows the largest standardized difference in unadjusted means between any pair of treatment arms.

Var	Type	Max.Diff.Un
pid5_num	Contin.	0.02
education_yrs	Contin.	0.05
age	Contin.	0.11
sex_Male	Binary	0.02
faminc_num	Contin.	0.08
econ_pre	Contin.	0.05
white	Binary	0.03
newsint	Contin.	0.08

B.5.1 Differential Attrition

Table A6: Survey completion rate by experimental treatment assignment

group	attrition_rate	n
1: Positive Article, Negative Comments	0.973	620
2: Positive Article, Neutral Comments	0.974	612
1: Negative Article, Negative Comments	0.969	617
1: Negative Article, Neutral Comments	0.973	619

I check to see if respondents who do not complete the survey differ by treatment assignment. Overall, there is very low attrition (2%) that is equivalent across treatment groups. There is no significant or substantive difference between groups; the largest difference is 0.3 percentage points with $p = 0.7$.

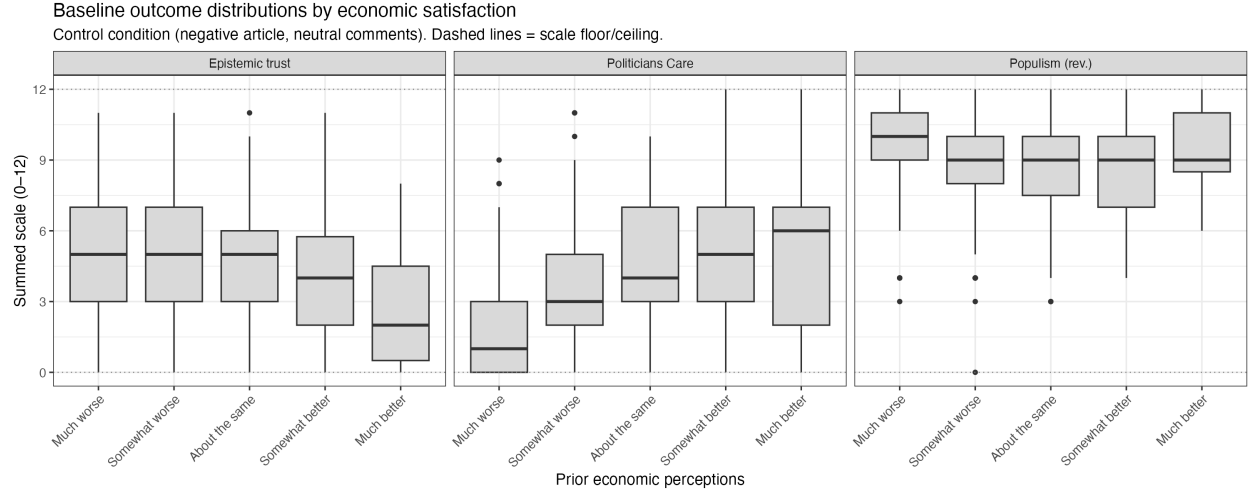


Figure A12: Baseline outcome distributions by prior economic satisfaction (control condition: negative article, neutral comments). Summed scales (0–12); higher = more trust/politicians care/populism. Dashed lines indicate scale floor and ceiling.

The baseline condition is negative economic news, which is expected to depress perceptions of elites through standard retrospective accountability logic (Fiorina, 1981) independent of the disconnect signaling mechanism. There is simply no remaining scale range for a positive article to push negative-prior respondents further downward via mismatch.

C Additional Experimental Analysis

C.1 Economic Perceptions: Article Average Marginal Effects

Figure A13 supplements Figure 5 in the main text by showing the average marginal effect of the positive article estimated separately at neutral and negative comment conditions, using a fully interacted model. The regression coefficients for this model can be found in Table A16.

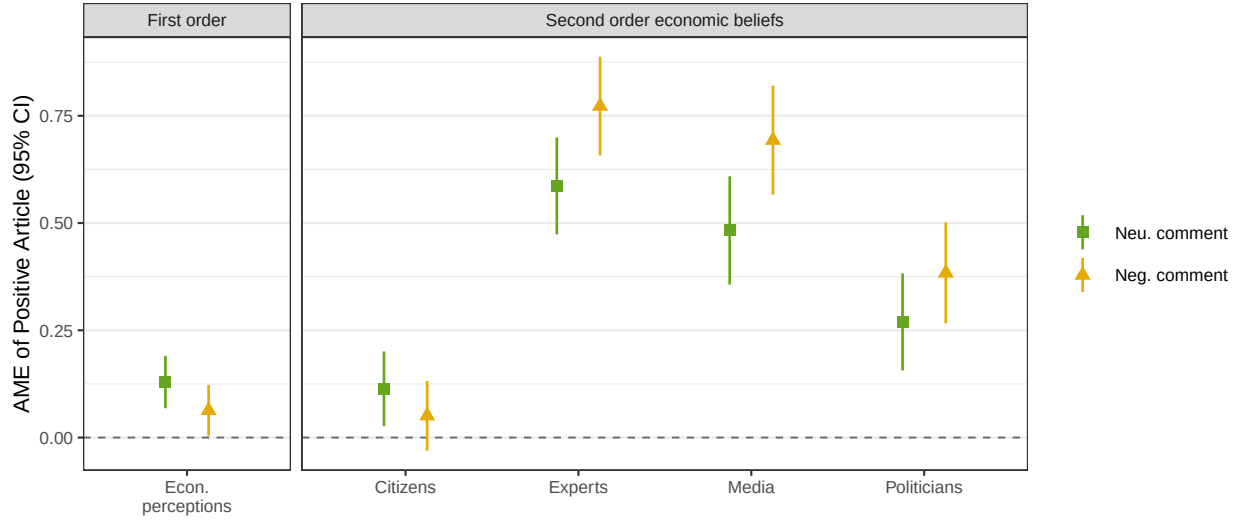
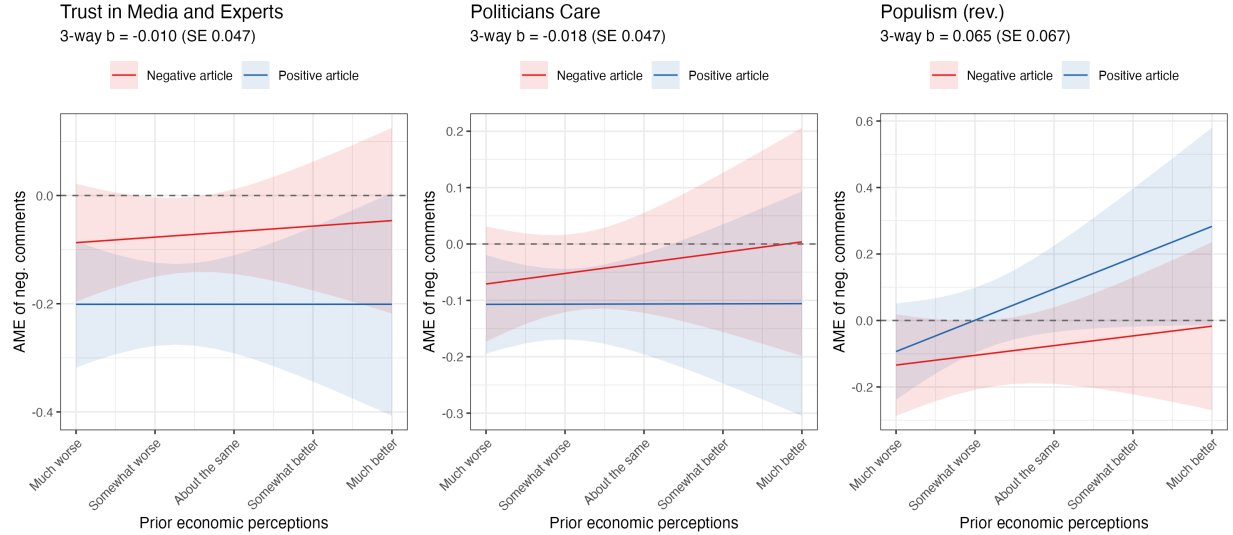


Figure A13: Average marginal effect of positive article on first- and second-order economic perceptions, estimated separately at neutral and negative comment conditions (fully interacted OLS model with preregistered covariate adjustment). Green = neutral comments; orange = negative comments. Error bars = 95% CI.

C.2 Triple Interaction: Comment Mismatch by Economic Prior

Figure A14 plots the average marginal effect of negative comments (vs. neutral), estimated separately for positive- and negative-article conditions, over the distribution of pre-treatment economic perceptions, from the triple interaction specification ($PA \times NC \times EP$) discussed in Section 5. The slopes are flat in both article conditions for the trust in media and experts and politicians care outcomes; the effect of comment mismatch does not change based on pre-treatment economic beliefs. I also observe a not-statistically significant but substantive difference in slopes for the people-centric populism outcome. These results suggest that while economically satisfied readers update their perceptions about public economic mood, this in fact translates to lower preferences for popular sovereignty, not more; however, this interpretation is necessarily speculative.

Figure A14: Triple Interaction: Negative Comment Effect by Article Tone and Pre-Treatment Economic Perceptions



Notes: Average marginal effect of negative comments (vs. neutral) across the prior economic satisfaction distribution, estimated using a linear specification and preregistered covariate adjustment. Shading = 95% CI. Marginal effect lines plotted separately for positive and negative articles.

C.3 Economic Perceptions: Effects By Economic Prior

Figure A15 shows marginal treatment effects on first- and second-order economic perception outcomes by pre-treatment economic perceptions using an OLS model that regresses the outcome on the triple interaction *Positive Article* $\times$ *Negative Comment* $\times$ *Economic Perception (Pre)*. The regression coefficients for this model can be found in Table A17. For ease of interpretability, the top panels of the figure show the average marginal effect of positive article exposure by comment condition on elite-oriented second-order economic perceptions while the bottom panels show the average marginal effect of negative comment exposure by article condition on citizen-oriented second-order beliefs and first-order economic perceptions. This analysis is exploratory and was not preregistered, but highlights two additional findings that further support disconnect signaling theory.

First, the effects of exposure to negative comments on respondents' perceptions of public economic sentiment support the comment-learning account of disconnect signaling theory. Negative comments lead economically satisfied respondents to view ordinary citizens as more pessimistic about the economy while economically dissatisfied respondents likely already assume that the public holds negative views of economic conditions. Moreover, this effect is concentrated in the positive article condition rather than the negative article condition. Economically satisfied respondents who read a positive article accompanied by negative comments are exposed to the greatest opportunity for learning, as the comments provide the only signal that contradicts the article's favorable portrayal of the economy. By contrast, the negative article condition reduces the additional informational value of the comments. However, this learning primarily affects second-order beliefs about public sentiment and does not necessarily extend to respondents' own assessments of economic conditions.

Second, positive articles increase elite second-order beliefs more among respondents who were initially pessimistic about the economy. This pattern is consistent with pessimistic respondents entering the experiment with lower priors about elite economic optimism, whereas optimistic respondents may already hold relatively high pre-treatment beliefs about elite views, leaving less room for updating. Importantly, this effect is strongest when positive articles are paired with negative comments. This pattern is consistent with a signal-differentiation mechanism. For pessimistic respondents, negative comments align with their prior beliefs about public economic sentiment, while the positive article does not. The disagreement between the two sources makes the article more clearly identifiable as an elite signal. As a result, respondents can more readily attribute the positive economic assessment to elites and update their beliefs about elite views accordingly.

Stimulus effects $\times$ econ_pre

Top: AME of positive article by comment tone on elite meta-beliefs; Bottom: AME of negative comment by article tone on citizen meta-beliefs

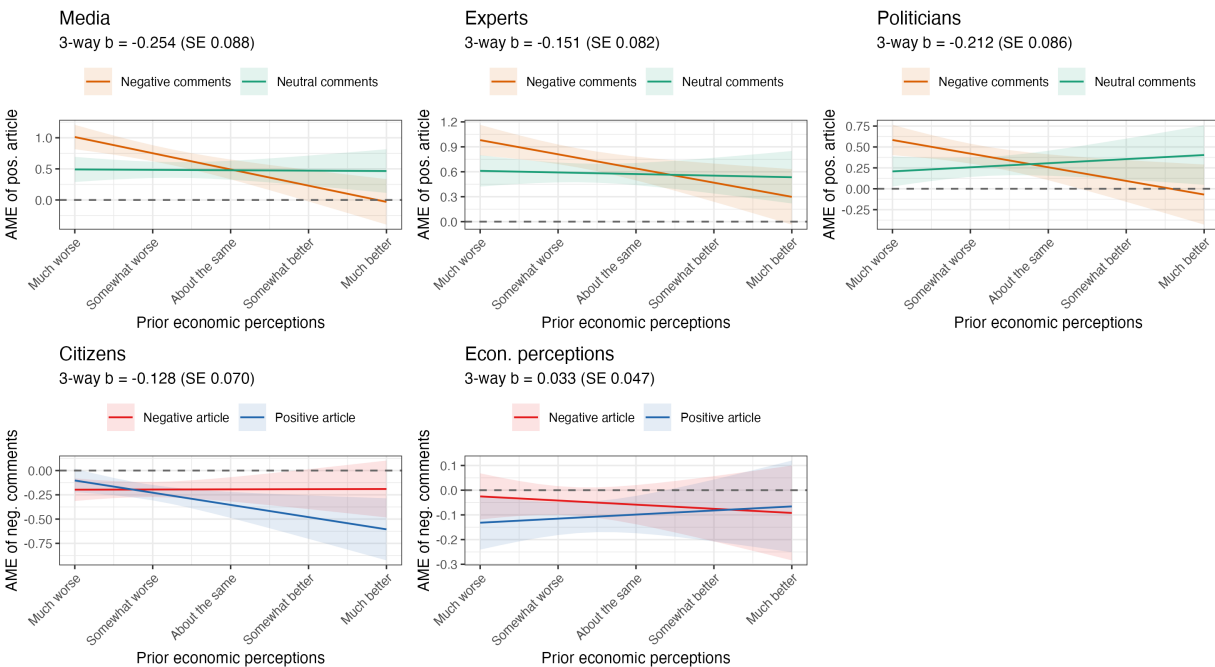


Figure A15: Average marginal effect of stimuli tone on manipulation-check outcomes across *econ_pre* and across comment tone. Full 2×2 sample, controlling for preregistered covariates. Top: AME of positive article by comment tone on elite meta-beliefs; Bottom: AME of negative comment by article tone on citizen meta-beliefs.

C.4 Article Backlash: Elite Perception Movers as Compliers (IV)

I use a preregistered exploratory IV/CACE analysis to test the theoretical mechanism: are the H1 effects on trust in media and experts and on politicians care driven by article exposure causing changes in elite second-order beliefs? The manipulation checks analysis provides suggestive evidence, showing that positive article exposure causes respondents to infer that politicians, media organizations, and experts view the economy more positively; addi-

tional analysis shows that this effect is stronger for respondents with negative priors (Appendix C.3). To investigate the mechanism more rigorously, I use an instrumental variables analysis where random assignment instruments for change in second-order beliefs to estimate the complier average causal treatment effect (CACE) for negative-prior respondents and positive-prior respondents separately. Using this analytical framework, I am able to recover estimates of elite metaperceptions on trust outcomes.

Table A7: IV/CACE estimates by prior economic perception subgroup

Group	Outcome	N	First Stage F	CACE	SE
Economy Worse	elite_responsiveness	1544	231.5	0.030	(0.048)
Economy Worse	epistemic_trust	1544	231.5	-0.275***	(0.057)
Economy Same or Better	elite_responsiveness	705	55.9	0.258*	(0.125)
Economy Same or Better	epistemic_trust	705	55.9	0.157	(0.112)
All	elite_responsiveness	2249	278.5	0.078	(0.046)
All	epistemic_trust	2249	278.5	-0.174**	(0.050)

Table A7 shows the results. Among respondents with negative priors (who felt that the economy was either “somewhat worse” or “much worse”), the CACE is substantively negative: -0.275 . Among respondents with neutral or positive priors, the CACE is not distinguishable from zero. These results provide strong evidence that trust is affected primarily through movement of second-order beliefs, and that movement of these beliefs causes declines in trust only for negative prior participants.

Dependent Variable:	so.elite_avg		
Model:	Worse (1)	Same/Better (2)	All (3)
Constant	2.5*** (0.35)	3.8*** (0.47)	3.3*** (0.27)
Pos. article	0.58*** (0.04)	0.41*** (0.05)	0.53*** (0.03)
Neg. comment	-0.007 (0.04)	-0.006 (0.06)	-0.006 (0.03)
Econ pre	0.07 (0.04)	-0.05 (0.06)	-0.02 (0.02)
Will of the people (pre)	0.03 (0.03)	0.03 (0.03)	0.03 (0.02)
System stacked (pre)	0.03 (0.02)	0.05* (0.03)	0.04* (0.02)
Officials care (pre, rev)	0.05** (0.03)	-0.09*** (0.03)	-0.02 (0.02)
News media fair (pre, rev)	0.07*** (0.02)	-0.16*** (0.03)	-0.01 (0.02)
Trust experts (pre, rev)	0.06*** (0.02)	0.003 (0.03)	0.04** (0.01)
News interest	-0.03 (0.02)	-0.005 (0.03)	-0.05*** (0.02)
Democrat	-0.12** (0.06)	-0.17 (0.11)	-0.16*** (0.05)
Republican	-0.06 (0.07)	-0.15* (0.09)	-0.11** (0.05)
Education (yrs)	-0.01 (0.008)	-0.01 (0.01)	-0.008 (0.007)
Log income	-0.04 (0.03)	0.04 (0.04)	-0.02 (0.02)
Econ identity (pre)	0.02 (0.03)	-0.07** (0.04)	-0.01 (0.02)
Observations	1,540	703	2,243

Heteroskedasticity-robust standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table A8: First-stage regressions: instrument (*article_pos_tone*) on endogenous regressor (*so_elite_avg*, the average elite second-order belief). “Worse” = *econ_pre* ≤ 2; “Same/Better” = *econ_pre* ≥ 3. Coefficient on *Pos. article* gives the first-stage strength of the instrument within each subgroup.

Dependent Variables:	Trust Media/Experts			Politicians Care		
Model:	Trust: Worse (1)	Trust: Same/Better (2)	Trust: All (3)	Resp.: Worse (4)	Resp.: Same/Better (5)	Resp.: All (6)
Constant	3.3*** (0.30)	2.9*** (0.66)	3.5*** (0.29)	2.8*** (0.29)	2.2*** (0.69)	2.7*** (0.28)
Elite SO (instrumented)	-0.27*** (0.06)	0.16 (0.11)	-0.17*** (0.05)	0.03 (0.05)	0.26** (0.13)	0.08* (0.05)
Neg. comment	-0.14*** (0.03)	-0.15*** (0.04)	-0.14*** (0.03)	-0.08*** (0.03)	-0.09* (0.05)	-0.08*** (0.02)
Econ pre	0.14*** (0.04)	-0.07 (0.05)	0.009 (0.02)	0.08*** (0.03)	0.06 (0.05)	0.07*** (0.02)
Will of the people (pre)	-0.05** (0.03)	-0.06 (0.04)	-0.05** (0.02)	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.08** (0.03)	-0.07*** (0.02)
System stacked (pre)	-0.04** (0.02)	-0.09*** (0.03)	-0.05*** (0.01)	-0.31*** (0.02)	-0.39*** (0.03)	-0.33*** (0.02)
Officials care (pre, rev)	-0.04* (0.02)	-0.11*** (0.03)	-0.08*** (0.02)	-0.42*** (0.02)	-0.41*** (0.04)	-0.42*** (0.02)
News media fair (pre, rev)	-0.32*** (0.02)	-0.34*** (0.03)	-0.35*** (0.01)	-0.06*** (0.01)	-0.03 (0.04)	-0.06*** (0.01)
Trust experts (pre, rev)	-0.44*** (0.02)	-0.35*** (0.03)	-0.42*** (0.01)	-0.04*** (0.01)	0.006 (0.03)	-0.03** (0.01)
News interest	0.04** (0.02)	0.01 (0.03)	0.02 (0.01)	-0.01 (0.02)	0.01 (0.03)	0.003 (0.01)
Democrat	0.06 (0.05)	0.14 (0.10)	0.07* (0.04)	0.01 (0.04)	0.03 (0.11)	0.03 (0.04)
Republican	-0.19*** (0.06)	-0.03 (0.08)	-0.15*** (0.04)	-0.02 (0.05)	0.10 (0.09)	0.03 (0.04)
Education (yrs)	0.010 (0.007)	0.02* (0.010)	0.01** (0.006)	0.0005 (0.006)	-0.006 (0.01)	-0.002 (0.005)
Log income	0.01 (0.02)	-0.007 (0.03)	0.02 (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)	0.007 (0.03)	0.01 (0.01)
Econ identity (pre)	-0.004 (0.02)	-0.02 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.02)	0.08*** (0.02)	0.11*** (0.03)	0.09*** (0.02)
Observations	1,540	703	2,243	1,540	703	2,243

Heteroskedasticity-robust standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table A9: Full IV/CACE (second-stage) regression coefficients by prior economic perception. Endogenous regressor: average elite second-order belief (*so_elite_avg*), instrumented by random article-tone assignment. Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors in parentheses.

C.5 Stimulus Variation

A potential concern is that results reflect idiosyncratic features of the stimulus rather than the concept of interest (Fong and Grimmer, 2023). This concern primarily affects the theory’s scope conditions; namely, to what extent the mechanism illustrated on a limited set of stimuli is portable to the ecological population of economic news, which may differ in multiple ways. To address this concern, in addition to article and comment tone participants were also randomly assigned to one of two article topics: general economic conditions or unemployment. The preregistered primary specification used in the main text presents estimates which are pooled across the two topic conditions which anchor different positions on a tradeoff between treatment strength and ecological validity. In this section, I discuss the differences between the two topic conditions and present robustness analysis estimating effects for each topic condition.

The positive general economic conditions stimulus article was constructed as a strong

treatment, covering multiple economic indicators and featuring an expert quote that directly links economic developments to the welfare of ordinary households. Although I argue that the general conditions article is a “strong treatment,” it still is well within plausible levels of realism. In fact, the week before experiment launch, CNBC published an article featuring an economist quoted as saying, “Inflation fell to its lowest level since May and key items such as food, gas and rent are cooling off. This will provide much needed relief for middle class and moderate-income families.” An inflation-focused stimulus article using this quote was not used in the full study because pre-test participants actually rated it below an acceptable threshold for realism, despite being minimally adapted from a real news article.

The second topic condition (unemployment) was minimally adapted from a real CNBC news article about jobs data released in early February 2026. Both negative and positive versions of each article topic were pre-tested for realism and article tone; the jobs topic condition was rated as slightly more realistic overall and with a smaller gap in perceived tone between positive and negative articles. On a 5-point scale, the positive (negative) jobs article was rated a 4.27 (2.0) for tone and 3.5 (4.1) for realism, while the positive (negative) general article was rated 4.7 (1.8) for tone and 3.3 (4.1) for realism in a N=120 pre-test. Given the weaker perceived difference in tone, I expect the jobs article to have attenuated effects in comparison to the general conditions article which represents a cleaner test of the theoretical mechanism. I do not claim that the two article topics represent the entirety of the population of economic news; however, they do serve as informative points on a spectrum of stimuli strength and ecological validity.

The article backlash for negative-prior readers is robust to stimulus choice: while the jobs topic condition shows the expected attenuated effect, H1a and H1b remain directionally consistent and in some cases retain statistical significance when estimated in independent topic conditions. The difference between the coefficient of interest is not statistically significant between topic conditions. Similar results hold for H2a.

Dependent Variables: Model:	Trust Media/Experts (1)	(2)	Politicians Care (3)	(4)	People-centrism (rev.) (5)	(6)
Constant	3.0*** (0.23)	2.9*** (0.23)	3.1*** (0.22)	3.0*** (0.21)	2.7*** (0.33)	2.6*** (0.32)
Pos. article	-0.45*** (0.09)	-0.04 (0.05)	-0.08 (0.08)	0.08* (0.05)	-0.008 (0.12)	-0.04 (0.07)
Econ pre	-0.04* (0.03)	0.01 (0.02)	0.03 (0.03)	0.07*** (0.02)	0.02 (0.04)	0.04 (0.02)
Jobs topic	-0.01 (0.08)	-0.01 (0.05)	-0.01 (0.08)	0.01 (0.05)	-0.01 (0.12)	0.03 (0.07)
Neg. comment	-0.14*** (0.03)	-0.07 (0.05)	-0.08*** (0.02)	-0.08 (0.05)	-0.04 (0.04)	-0.09 (0.07)
Will of the people (pre)	-0.06*** (0.02)	-0.06*** (0.02)	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.48*** (0.04)	-0.48*** (0.04)
System stacked (pre)	-0.06*** (0.01)	-0.06*** (0.01)	-0.33*** (0.02)	-0.33*** (0.02)	-0.13*** (0.02)	-0.13*** (0.02)
Officials care (pre, rev)	-0.08*** (0.02)	-0.08*** (0.02)	-0.42*** (0.02)	-0.43*** (0.02)	-0.10*** (0.02)	-0.10*** (0.02)
News media fair (pre, rev)	-0.35*** (0.01)	-0.35*** (0.01)	-0.06*** (0.01)	-0.06*** (0.01)	0.007 (0.02)	0.007 (0.02)
Trust experts (pre, rev)	-0.42*** (0.01)	-0.43*** (0.01)	-0.02** (0.01)	-0.02** (0.01)	-0.08*** (0.02)	-0.08*** (0.02)
News interest	0.03* (0.01)	0.03* (0.01)	-0.0006 (0.01)	-0.002 (0.01)	-0.04** (0.02)	-0.04** (0.02)
Democrat	0.10** (0.04)	0.10** (0.04)	0.01 (0.04)	0.01 (0.04)	-0.14** (0.06)	-0.14** (0.06)
Republican	-0.13*** (0.04)	-0.14*** (0.04)	0.02 (0.04)	0.02 (0.04)	-0.13** (0.06)	-0.13** (0.06)
Education (yrs)	0.01*** (0.006)	0.01** (0.006)	-0.003 (0.005)	-0.003 (0.005)	0.02*** (0.008)	0.02*** (0.008)
Log income	0.02 (0.02)	0.02 (0.02)	0.01 (0.01)	0.01 (0.01)	0.03 (0.02)	0.03 (0.02)
Econ identity (pre)	-0.02 (0.02)	-0.02 (0.02)	0.09*** (0.02)	0.09*** (0.02)	0.02 (0.03)	0.02 (0.03)
Pos. article × Econ pre	0.14*** (0.03)		0.07* (0.04)		0.02 (0.05)	
Pos. article × Jobs topic	0.20* (0.12)	0.03 (0.07)	0.01 (0.11)	-0.02 (0.07)	-0.02 (0.16)	0.02 (0.10)
Econ pre × Jobs topic	0.001 (0.03)		0.03 (0.03)		0.01 (0.04)	
Pos. article × Econ pre × Jobs topic	-0.05 (0.05)		-0.02 (0.05)		0.005 (0.07)	
Neg. comment × Pos. article		-0.18** (0.07)		-0.04 (0.07)		0.14 (0.10)
Neg. comment × Jobs topic		0.004 (0.07)		0.06 (0.07)		-0.02 (0.10)
Neg. comment × Pos. article × Jobs		0.11 (0.10)		-0.04 (0.10)		-0.05 (0.14)
Observations	2,245	2,245	2,245	2,245	2,245	2,245

Heteroskedasticity-robust standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table A10: Article backlash and comment mismatch effects across stimulus topic conditions. The three-way interactions (*article_pos_tone* × *econ_pre_z* × *article_topicJobs*) and (*comment_neg_tone* × *article_pos_tone* × *article_topicJobs*) test whether H1 and H2 effects differ between article topics.

C.6 Partisan Heterogeneity

The preregistered moderator for H1 (Article Backlash) is a measure of pre-treatment economic perceptions. This measure was chosen because it is the most theoretically relevant quantity — the disconnect signaling theory specifically states that distrust and disconnect arise when contradictory institutional signals clash with prior evaluations of the economy.

One potential concern is that because partisanship and economic perceptions are correlated ($r = 0.55$), results are driven more from partisan motivated reasoning than disconnect signaling. This is plausible; during a Republican (Trump) administration, positive articles could cause Democrats (negative economic perceptions) to decrease trust in media (and vice versa for Republicans).

To analyze the extent to which this potential confounding may affect results, I estimate effects within partisan subgroups separately. I choose this analysis strategy as opposed to estimating an interaction model for simplicity. Table A11 shows the regression coefficients for the article backlash hypothesis (H1) while Table A12 estimates the H2 interaction. The interaction coefficient of positive article tone $\times$ econ_pre is substantively similar across party groups, indicating that within partisanship categories, positive article exposure causes economically dissatisfied respondents to decrease trust and politicians care perceptions and vice versa for economically satisfied respondents. Similarly, the comment mismatch effect (H2) on trust in media and experts is similar across partisan groups. The similarity of the economic perceptions interaction across partisan subgroups suggests that disconnect signaling’s effect on media and expert trust operates independently from partisan motivated reasoning.

The most notable partisan heterogeneity is that comment mismatch causes Republicans to feel that politicians care less but at the same time reduces populist attitudes while leaving Democrats relatively unaffected. One possible interpretation of this heterogeneity is that Republicans interpret comment mismatch as evidence that politicians are less responsive to ordinary citizens; the fact that populism moves in the opposite direction may reflect more complex heterogeneity even within the subgroup. Given the exploratory nature of these analyses, this interpretation is purely speculative.

Dependent Variables: Model:	Trust Media/Experts		Politicians Care		People-centrism (rev.)	
	Democrats	Republicans	Democrats	Republicans	Democrats	Republicans
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Constant	3.1*** (0.30)	2.8*** (0.35)	3.0*** (0.28)	2.9*** (0.34)	2.9*** (0.49)	2.7*** (0.48)
Pos. article	-0.15*** (0.05)	0.01 (0.04)	0.03 (0.05)	0.12*** (0.04)	0.05 (0.07)	0.10* (0.06)
Econ pre (z)	-0.04 (0.05)	-0.07** (0.03)	0.007 (0.06)	0.02 (0.03)	0.04 (0.06)	0.02 (0.05)
Neg. comment	-0.19*** (0.04)	-0.13*** (0.04)	-0.10*** (0.03)	-0.14*** (0.04)	-0.09* (0.05)	-0.02 (0.06)
Will of the people (pre)	-0.008 (0.03)	-0.10*** (0.03)	-0.05** (0.02)	-0.07** (0.03)	-0.45*** (0.06)	-0.50*** (0.06)
System stacked (pre)	-0.06*** (0.02)	-0.05** (0.02)	-0.31*** (0.02)	-0.35*** (0.03)	-0.17*** (0.03)	-0.09*** (0.03)
Officials care (pre, rev)	-0.04* (0.02)	-0.11*** (0.03)	-0.41*** (0.03)	-0.40*** (0.03)	-0.07** (0.04)	-0.12*** (0.04)
News media fair (pre, rev)	-0.35*** (0.02)	-0.32*** (0.03)	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.05** (0.02)	-0.005 (0.03)	0.03 (0.03)
Trust experts (pre, rev)	-0.48*** (0.02)	-0.37*** (0.02)	-0.01 (0.01)	-0.02 (0.02)	-0.10*** (0.02)	-0.06* (0.03)
News interest	0.03 (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)	-0.03 (0.02)	0.006 (0.02)	-0.01 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.03)
Education (yrs)	0.010 (0.009)	0.01 (0.009)	0.004 (0.008)	-0.006 (0.008)	0.02* (0.01)	0.02 (0.01)
Log income	0.006 (0.03)	0.04 (0.03)	0.01 (0.02)	0.03 (0.03)	-0.002 (0.04)	0.02 (0.04)
Econ identity (pre)	-0.02 (0.03)	-0.04 (0.03)	0.08*** (0.03)	0.11*** (0.03)	0.02 (0.04)	0.04 (0.04)
Pos. article $\times$ Econ pre	0.12** (0.06)	0.13*** (0.04)	0.09 (0.07)	0.08** (0.04)	0.06 (0.08)	0.05 (0.06)
Observations	1,070	798	1,070	798	1,070	798

Heteroskedasticity-robust standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table A11: Article backlash effect (H1) estimated separately for party subgroups. Models (1), (3), and (5) estimate for Democratic leaners; models (2), (4), and (6) estimate for Republican leaners.

Dependent Variables:	Trust Media/Experts		Politicians Care		People-centrism (rev.)	
Model:	Democrats	Republicans	Democrats	Republicans	Democrats	Republicans
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Constant	3.1*** (0.31)	2.7*** (0.36)	2.9*** (0.29)	2.8*** (0.34)	2.8*** (0.52)	2.6*** (0.48)
Neg. comment	-0.14*** (0.05)	-0.09 (0.06)	-0.13*** (0.05)	-0.06 (0.06)	-0.14* (0.08)	-0.15* (0.08)
Pos. article	-0.17*** (0.05)	0.08 (0.06)	-0.05 (0.05)	0.23*** (0.06)	-0.02 (0.08)	-0.009 (0.08)
Econ pre	0.02 (0.03)	-0.007 (0.02)	0.05 (0.03)	0.05** (0.02)	0.07 (0.04)	0.04 (0.04)
Will of the people (pre)	-0.01 (0.03)	-0.10*** (0.03)	-0.05** (0.02)	-0.07** (0.03)	-0.45*** (0.06)	-0.50*** (0.06)
System stacked (pre)	-0.06*** (0.02)	-0.05** (0.02)	-0.31*** (0.02)	-0.35*** (0.03)	-0.17*** (0.03)	-0.09*** (0.03)
Officials care (pre, rev)	-0.05** (0.02)	-0.11*** (0.03)	-0.41*** (0.03)	-0.40*** (0.03)	-0.07** (0.04)	-0.12*** (0.04)
News media fair (pre, rev)	-0.35*** (0.02)	-0.33*** (0.03)	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.05** (0.02)	-0.005 (0.03)	0.03 (0.03)
Trust experts (pre, rev)	-0.48*** (0.02)	-0.37*** (0.02)	-0.01 (0.01)	-0.02 (0.02)	-0.10*** (0.02)	-0.06** (0.03)
News interest	0.03 (0.02)	0.009 (0.02)	-0.03 (0.02)	0.002 (0.02)	-0.01 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.03)
Education (yrs)	0.010 (0.009)	0.01 (0.009)	0.004 (0.008)	-0.007 (0.008)	0.02* (0.01)	0.02 (0.01)
Log income	0.007 (0.03)	0.04 (0.03)	0.01 (0.02)	0.03 (0.03)	-0.001 (0.04)	0.02 (0.04)
Econ identity (pre)	-0.02 (0.03)	-0.04 (0.03)	0.08*** (0.03)	0.11*** (0.03)	0.02 (0.04)	0.03 (0.04)
Neg. comment $\times$ Pos. article	-0.09 (0.08)	-0.09 (0.08)	0.06 (0.07)	-0.17** (0.08)	0.09 (0.10)	0.25** (0.12)
Observations	1,070	798	1,070	798	1,070	798

Heteroskedasticity-robust standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table A12: Comment mismatch effect (H2) estimated separately for party subgroups. Models (1), (3), and (5) estimate for Democratic leaners; models (2), (4), and (6) estimate for Republican leaners. The interaction coefficient *Neg. comment* $\times$ *Pos. article* is the H2 mismatch estimate.

C.7 Exploratory Analysis: Income, News Interest

The effect of positive article exposure on disconnect outcomes may be heterogeneous by news interest or income in addition to pre-treatment economic perceptions.

Dependent Variables: Model:	Trust Media/Experts		Politicians Care			People-centrism (rev.)	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)
Constant	2.7*** (0.23)	2.9*** (0.33)	3.0*** (0.21)	3.1*** (0.31)	3.0*** (0.21)	3.2*** (0.49)	2.5*** (0.33)
Pos. article	0.21** (0.10)	0.01 (0.35)	-0.03 (0.09)	-0.18 (0.31)	-0.03 (0.09)	-0.83* (0.47)	0.10 (0.13)
News interest	0.10*** (0.02)	0.03* (0.01)	-0.008 (0.02)	-0.001 (0.01)	-0.008 (0.02)	-0.04** (0.02)	-0.02 (0.04)
Neg. comment	-0.003 (0.09)	-0.33 (0.35)	-0.05 (0.09)	-0.06 (0.31)	-0.05 (0.09)	-0.24 (0.46)	0.07 (0.13)
Econ pre	0.01 (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)	0.07*** (0.02)	0.07*** (0.02)	0.07*** (0.02)	0.04 (0.02)	0.04 (0.02)
Will of the people (pre)	-0.05*** (0.02)	-0.06*** (0.02)	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.48*** (0.04)	-0.48*** (0.04)
System stacked (pre)	-0.06*** (0.01)	-0.06*** (0.01)	-0.33*** (0.02)	-0.33*** (0.02)	-0.33*** (0.02)	-0.13*** (0.02)	-0.13*** (0.02)
Officials care (pre, rev)	-0.08*** (0.02)	-0.08*** (0.02)	-0.42*** (0.02)	-0.43*** (0.02)	-0.42*** (0.02)	-0.10*** (0.02)	-0.10*** (0.02)
News media fair (pre, rev)	-0.35*** (0.01)	-0.35*** (0.01)	-0.06*** (0.01)	-0.06*** (0.01)	-0.06*** (0.01)	0.006 (0.02)	0.007 (0.02)
Trust experts (pre, rev)	-0.43*** (0.01)	-0.43*** (0.01)	-0.02** (0.01)	-0.02** (0.01)	-0.02** (0.01)	-0.08*** (0.02)	-0.08*** (0.02)
Democrat	0.10** (0.04)	0.10** (0.04)	0.01 (0.04)	0.01 (0.04)	0.01 (0.04)	-0.14** (0.06)	-0.14** (0.06)
Republican	-0.13*** (0.04)	-0.13*** (0.04)	0.02 (0.04)	0.02 (0.04)	0.02 (0.04)	-0.14** (0.06)	-0.13** (0.06)
Education (yrs)	0.01*** (0.006)	0.01*** (0.006)	-0.003 (0.005)	-0.003 (0.005)	-0.003 (0.005)	0.02*** (0.008)	0.02*** (0.008)
Log income	0.02 (0.02)	0.01 (0.03)	0.01 (0.01)	0.004 (0.03)	0.01 (0.01)	-0.01 (0.04)	0.03 (0.02)
Econ identity (pre)	-0.02 (0.02)	-0.02 (0.02)	0.09*** (0.02)	0.09*** (0.02)	0.09*** (0.02)	0.02 (0.03)	0.02 (0.03)
Pos. article × News interest	-0.10*** (0.03)		0.02 (0.03)		0.02 (0.03)		-0.02 (0.04)
News interest × Neg. comment	-0.04 (0.03)		-0.009 (0.03)		-0.009 (0.03)		-0.03 (0.04)
Pos. article × Log income		-0.010 (0.03)		0.02 (0.03)		0.08* (0.04)	
Log income × Neg. comment		0.02 (0.03)		-0.002 (0.03)		0.02 (0.04)	
Observations	2,245	2,245	2,245	2,245	2,245	2,245	2,245

Heteroskedasticity-robust standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table A13: Exploratory: household income and news interest as moderators of main article and comment treatment effects.

Income moderator effects are largely null with the exception of populism. This suggests that the primary divergence mechanism operates through perception and cognition rather than objective socioeconomic position. News interest effects are largely null with the ex-

ception of trust in media and experts. This finding is exploratory, but one possibility is that respondents with higher news interest may already be skeptical of positive economic coverage from prior exposure, amplifying distrust when exposed to a positive article.¹⁹

D Regression Tables and Robustness

Regression tables in this appendix report the full set of estimated coefficients, including all preregistered covariates.

¹⁹The correlation of news interest with pre-treatment economic perceptions is extremely low: $r = -0.02$, suggesting that news interest captures something other than just proxying for negative economic priors.

D.1 Manipulation Check Outcomes

Dependent Variables: Model:	econ_post (1)	so_media (2)	so_experts (3)	so_pols (4)	so_citizen (5)	article_trust (6)
Constant	0.63*** (0.19)	3.3*** (0.38)	2.6*** (0.35)	3.9*** (0.35)	0.93*** (0.27)	3.2*** (0.34)
Pos. article	0.10*** (0.02)	0.59*** (0.05)	0.68*** (0.04)	0.33*** (0.04)	0.08*** (0.03)	-0.61*** (0.04)
Neg. comment	-0.08*** (0.02)	0.002 (0.05)	-0.05 (0.04)	0.03 (0.04)	-0.23*** (0.03)	0.007 (0.04)
Econ pre	0.75*** (0.02)	-0.17*** (0.03)	0.21*** (0.03)	-0.09*** (0.03)	0.47*** (0.02)	0.001 (0.03)
Will of the people (pre)	-0.01 (0.02)	0.03 (0.03)	-0.03 (0.03)	0.08*** (0.03)	-0.02 (0.02)	0.0004 (0.03)
System stacked (pre)	-0.03** (0.01)	0.07*** (0.03)	0.03 (0.02)	-0.0003 (0.02)	-0.001 (0.02)	-0.005 (0.02)
Officials care (pre, rev)	-0.04*** (0.01)	-0.04 (0.03)	-0.06** (0.03)	0.04 (0.03)	-0.09*** (0.02)	-0.08*** (0.03)
News media fair (pre, rev)	0.02** (0.01)	-0.04 (0.02)	-0.04 (0.02)	0.03 (0.02)	0.0007 (0.02)	-0.18*** (0.02)
Trust experts (pre, rev)	0.01 (0.01)	0.03 (0.02)	0.08*** (0.02)	-0.004 (0.02)	0.04*** (0.01)	-0.06*** (0.02)
News interest	0.006 (0.01)	-0.05* (0.03)	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.02 (0.02)	0.04** (0.02)	0.05** (0.02)
Democrat	-0.05 (0.04)	-0.21*** (0.07)	-0.17*** (0.06)	-0.11* (0.06)	-0.03 (0.04)	0.06 (0.06)
Republican	0.05 (0.04)	-0.25*** (0.08)	0.08 (0.07)	-0.17*** (0.07)	0.06 (0.05)	0.07 (0.07)
Education (yrs)	-0.004 (0.005)	-0.008 (0.01)	-0.007 (0.009)	-0.01 (0.009)	-0.004 (0.007)	0.004 (0.009)
Log income	0.004 (0.02)	-0.02 (0.03)	-0.01 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.03)	-0.007 (0.02)	0.07** (0.03)
Econ identity (pre)	0.07*** (0.02)	-0.04 (0.03)	0.04 (0.03)	-0.04 (0.03)	0.11*** (0.02)	0.05 (0.03)
Observations	2,245	2,242	2,239	2,238	2,240	2,245

Heteroskedasticity-robust standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table A14: Main effects of positive article and negative comments on manipulation-check outcomes; pooled additive specification corresponding to Figure 5 in the main text.

Dependent Variables: Model:	econ_post (1)	so_media (2)	so_experts (3)	so_pols (4)	so_citizen (5)	article_trust (6)
Constant	0.65*** (0.19)	3.2*** (0.38)	2.4*** (0.36)	3.9*** (0.35)	0.95*** (0.27)	4.1*** (0.32)
Pos. article	0.05 (0.06)	0.88*** (0.11)	0.89*** (0.10)	0.45*** (0.10)	0.05 (0.07)	-2.2*** (0.09)
Econ pre	0.74*** (0.02)	-0.11*** (0.04)	0.26*** (0.04)	-0.06 (0.04)	0.47*** (0.03)	-0.36*** (0.03)
Neg. comment	-0.08*** (0.02)	0.002 (0.04)	-0.05 (0.04)	0.03 (0.04)	-0.23*** (0.03)	0.008 (0.04)
Will of the people (pre)	-0.01 (0.02)	0.03 (0.03)	-0.03 (0.03)	0.09*** (0.03)	-0.02 (0.02)	-0.006 (0.03)
System stacked (pre)	-0.03** (0.01)	0.07*** (0.03)	0.03 (0.02)	-0.0002 (0.02)	-0.001 (0.02)	-0.006 (0.02)
Officials care (pre, rev)	-0.04*** (0.01)	-0.04 (0.03)	-0.06** (0.03)	0.04 (0.03)	-0.09*** (0.02)	-0.07*** (0.02)
News media fair (pre, rev)	0.02** (0.01)	-0.04 (0.02)	-0.04 (0.02)	0.03 (0.02)	0.0007 (0.02)	-0.18*** (0.02)
Trust experts (pre, rev)	0.01 (0.01)	0.02 (0.02)	0.08*** (0.02)	-0.006 (0.02)	0.04*** (0.01)	-0.04** (0.02)
News interest	0.007 (0.01)	-0.05** (0.03)	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.03 (0.02)	0.04** (0.02)	0.06*** (0.02)
Democrat	-0.05 (0.04)	-0.21*** (0.07)	-0.17*** (0.06)	-0.11* (0.06)	-0.03 (0.04)	0.07 (0.06)
Republican	0.05 (0.04)	-0.25*** (0.08)	0.08 (0.07)	-0.17*** (0.07)	0.06 (0.05)	0.08 (0.06)
Education (yrs)	-0.004 (0.005)	-0.008 (0.01)	-0.007 (0.009)	-0.01 (0.009)	-0.004 (0.007)	0.005 (0.008)
Log income	0.004 (0.02)	-0.01 (0.03)	-0.01 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.03)	-0.007 (0.02)	0.05** (0.03)
Econ identity (pre)	0.07*** (0.02)	-0.04 (0.03)	0.04 (0.03)	-0.04 (0.03)	0.11*** (0.02)	0.06** (0.03)
Pos. article $\times$ Econ pre	0.02 (0.02)	-0.13*** (0.04)	-0.09** (0.04)	-0.06 (0.04)	0.01 (0.04)	0.71*** (0.04)
Observations	2,245	2,242	2,239	2,238	2,240	2,245

Heteroskedasticity-robust standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table A15: H1-style specification (positive article $\times$ prior economic perceptions) on manipulation-check outcomes.

Dependent Variables: Model:	econ_post (1)	so_media (2)	so_experts (3)	so_pols (4)	so_citizen (5)	article_trust (6)
Constant	0.62*** (0.19)	3.4*** (0.38)	2.6*** (0.35)	4.0*** (0.35)	0.92*** (0.27)	3.2*** (0.34)
Neg. comment	-0.05 (0.03)	-0.10* (0.06)	-0.15*** (0.06)	-0.03 (0.06)	-0.19*** (0.04)	0.12** (0.06)
Pos. article	0.13*** (0.03)	0.48*** (0.06)	0.59*** (0.06)	0.27*** (0.06)	0.11** (0.04)	-0.50*** (0.06)
Econ pre	0.75*** (0.02)	-0.17*** (0.03)	0.21*** (0.03)	-0.09*** (0.03)	0.47*** (0.02)	0.0001 (0.03)
Will of the people (pre)	-0.01 (0.02)	0.03 (0.03)	-0.03 (0.03)	0.09*** (0.03)	-0.02 (0.02)	-0.001 (0.03)
System stacked (pre)	-0.03** (0.01)	0.07*** (0.03)	0.03 (0.02)	-0.0008 (0.02)	-0.001 (0.02)	-0.004 (0.02)
Officials care (pre, rev)	-0.05*** (0.01)	-0.04 (0.03)	-0.05** (0.03)	0.04 (0.03)	-0.09*** (0.02)	-0.08*** (0.03)
News media fair (pre, rev)	0.02** (0.01)	-0.04 (0.02)	-0.04 (0.02)	0.03 (0.02)	0.0007 (0.02)	-0.18*** (0.02)
Trust experts (pre, rev)	0.01 (0.01)	0.03 (0.02)	0.08*** (0.02)	-0.005 (0.02)	0.04*** (0.01)	-0.06*** (0.02)
News interest	0.006 (0.01)	-0.05* (0.03)	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.02 (0.02)	0.04** (0.02)	0.05** (0.02)
Democrat	-0.05 (0.04)	-0.20*** (0.07)	-0.17*** (0.06)	-0.11* (0.06)	-0.03 (0.04)	0.06 (0.06)
Republican	0.05 (0.04)	-0.24*** (0.08)	0.09 (0.07)	-0.17** (0.07)	0.06 (0.05)	0.06 (0.07)
Education (yrs)	-0.004 (0.005)	-0.008 (0.01)	-0.007 (0.009)	-0.01 (0.009)	-0.004 (0.007)	0.004 (0.009)
Log income	0.005 (0.02)	-0.02 (0.03)	-0.01 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.03)	-0.007 (0.02)	0.07** (0.03)
Econ identity (pre)	0.07*** (0.02)	-0.04 (0.03)	0.04 (0.03)	-0.04 (0.03)	0.11*** (0.02)	0.05* (0.03)
Neg. comment $\times$ Pos. article	-0.07 (0.04)	0.21** (0.09)	0.19** (0.08)	0.11 (0.08)	-0.06 (0.06)	-0.23*** (0.08)
Observations	2,245	2,242	2,239	2,238	2,240	2,245

Heteroskedasticity-robust standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table A16: H2 mismatch on manipulation-check outcomes. Neg. comments $\times$ Pos. article is the interaction of interest.

Dependent Variables: Model:	econ_post (1)	so_media (2)	so_experts (3)	so_pols (4)	so_citizen (5)	article_trust (6)
Constant	0.62*** (0.20)	3.4*** (0.39)	2.6*** (0.36)	4.0*** (0.36)	0.97*** (0.28)	3.9*** (0.33)
Neg. comment	-0.008 (0.08)	-0.42*** (0.15)	-0.31** (0.13)	-0.30** (0.15)	-0.20** (0.10)	0.38*** (0.13)
Pos. article	0.12 (0.08)	0.50*** (0.16)	0.63*** (0.15)	0.16 (0.14)	-0.05 (0.11)	-1.9*** (0.13)
Econ pre	0.75*** (0.03)	-0.18*** (0.05)	0.22*** (0.05)	-0.12** (0.05)	0.46*** (0.04)	-0.29*** (0.04)
Will of the people (pre)	-0.01 (0.02)	0.03 (0.03)	-0.03 (0.03)	0.09*** (0.03)	-0.02 (0.02)	-0.008 (0.03)
System stacked (pre)	-0.03** (0.01)	0.07*** (0.03)	0.03 (0.02)	-0.0004 (0.02)	-0.002 (0.02)	-0.006 (0.02)
Officials care (pre, rev)	-0.04*** (0.01)	-0.04 (0.03)	-0.05** (0.03)	0.04 (0.03)	-0.09*** (0.02)	-0.08*** (0.02)
News media fair (pre, rev)	0.02** (0.01)	-0.04 (0.02)	-0.04* (0.02)	0.02 (0.02)	0.0005 (0.02)	-0.18*** (0.02)
Trust experts (pre, rev)	0.01 (0.01)	0.02 (0.02)	0.08*** (0.02)	-0.006 (0.02)	0.04*** (0.01)	-0.04** (0.02)
News interest	0.006 (0.01)	-0.05* (0.03)	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.02 (0.02)	0.04** (0.02)	0.06** (0.02)
Democrat	-0.05 (0.04)	-0.20*** (0.07)	-0.17*** (0.06)	-0.11* (0.06)	-0.03 (0.04)	0.06 (0.06)
Republican	0.05 (0.04)	-0.24*** (0.08)	0.09 (0.07)	-0.17** (0.07)	0.06 (0.05)	0.07 (0.06)
Education (yrs)	-0.004 (0.005)	-0.009 (0.01)	-0.008 (0.009)	-0.01 (0.009)	-0.005 (0.007)	0.005 (0.008)
Log income	0.004 (0.02)	-0.01 (0.03)	-0.01 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.03)	-0.006 (0.02)	0.05** (0.03)
Econ identity (pre)	0.07*** (0.02)	-0.05 (0.03)	0.04 (0.03)	-0.04 (0.03)	0.11*** (0.02)	0.06** (0.03)
Neg. comment $\times$ Pos. article	-0.14 (0.12)	0.78*** (0.22)	0.52** (0.20)	0.59*** (0.20)	0.22 (0.15)	-0.56*** (0.18)
Neg. comment $\times$ Econ pre	-0.02 (0.03)	0.14** (0.06)	0.07 (0.06)	0.12** (0.06)	0.002 (0.05)	-0.12** (0.05)
Pos. article $\times$ Econ pre	0.006 (0.04)	-0.006 (0.06)	-0.02 (0.06)	0.05 (0.06)	0.07 (0.05)	0.63*** (0.05)
Neg. comment $\times$ Pos. article $\times$ Econ pre	0.03 (0.05)	-0.25*** (0.09)	-0.15* (0.08)	-0.21** (0.09)	-0.13* (0.07)	0.16** (0.07)
Observations	2,245	2,242	2,239	2,238	2,240	2,245

Heteroskedasticity-robust standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table A17: RQ1 triple-interaction specification on manipulation-check outcomes. Neg. comment $\times$ Pos. article $\times$ Econ pre is the three-way interaction of interest.

D.2 Primary Specification Tables

These tables report the coefficients of the primary specification models used in the main text for both H1 and H2. The tables report models for all three disconnect outcomes: trust in media and experts, “politicians care,” and people-centric populism, as well as a preregistered index that combines both politicians care and people-centrism outcomes.

Dependent Variables: Model:	Trust Media/Experts (1)	(2)	Politicians Care (3)	(4)	People-centrism (rev.) (5)	(6)	Disconnect (7)	(8)
Constant	3.1*** (0.22)	2.9*** (0.22)	3.1*** (0.20)	3.0*** (0.21)	2.7*** (0.31)	2.6*** (0.32)	-3.5*** (0.24)	-3.4*** (0.24)
Pos. article	-0.36*** (0.06)	-0.03 (0.04)	-0.07 (0.05)	0.07** (0.03)	-0.03 (0.08)	-0.04 (0.05)	0.06 (0.06)	-0.03 (0.04)
Econ pre	-0.05** (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)	0.05** (0.02)	0.07*** (0.02)	0.02 (0.03)	0.04 (0.02)	-0.04** (0.02)	-0.07*** (0.02)
Neg. comment	-0.14*** (0.03)	-0.07** (0.04)	-0.08*** (0.02)	-0.05 (0.04)	-0.05 (0.04)	-0.10* (0.05)	0.07*** (0.03)	0.08** (0.04)
Will of the people (pre)	-0.05*** (0.02)	-0.06*** (0.02)	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.48*** (0.04)	-0.48*** (0.04)	0.30*** (0.03)	0.30*** (0.03)
System stacked (pre)	-0.06*** (0.01)	-0.06*** (0.01)	-0.33*** (0.01)	-0.33*** (0.02)	-0.14*** (0.02)	-0.13*** (0.02)	0.29*** (0.02)	0.29*** (0.02)
Officials care (pre, rev)	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.08*** (0.02)	-0.43*** (0.02)	-0.43*** (0.02)	-0.10*** (0.02)	-0.10*** (0.02)	0.34*** (0.02)	0.34*** (0.02)
News media fair (pre, rev)	-0.35*** (0.01)	-0.35*** (0.01)	-0.06*** (0.01)	-0.06*** (0.01)	0.0008 (0.02)	0.007 (0.02)	0.04** (0.01)	0.04** (0.01)
Trust experts (pre, rev)	-0.43*** (0.01)	-0.43*** (0.01)	-0.02** (0.01)	-0.02** (0.01)	-0.08*** (0.02)	-0.08*** (0.02)	0.06*** (0.01)	0.06*** (0.01)
News interest	0.03** (0.01)	0.03 (0.01)	0.002 (0.01)	-0.002 (0.01)	-0.04** (0.02)	-0.04** (0.02)	0.02 (0.01)	0.02 (0.01)
Democrat	0.13*** (0.04)	0.10** (0.04)	0.03 (0.04)	0.01 (0.04)	-0.16*** (0.06)	-0.14** (0.06)	0.07 (0.04)	0.07 (0.04)
Republican	-0.11*** (0.04)	-0.14*** (0.04)	0.03 (0.04)	0.02 (0.04)	-0.14** (0.06)	-0.13** (0.06)	0.06 (0.04)	0.06 (0.05)
Education (yrs)	0.01*** (0.006)	0.01*** (0.006)	-0.004 (0.005)	-0.003 (0.005)	0.03*** (0.008)	0.02*** (0.008)	-0.01* (0.006)	-0.01* (0.006)
Log income	0.006 (0.02)	0.02 (0.02)	0.01 (0.01)	0.01 (0.01)	0.03 (0.02)	0.03 (0.02)	-0.03 (0.02)	-0.03 (0.02)
Econ identity (pre)	-0.01 (0.02)	-0.02 (0.02)	0.09*** (0.02)	0.09*** (0.02)	0.02 (0.03)	0.02 (0.03)	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.07*** (0.02)
Pos. article $\times$ Econ pre	0.12*** (0.02)	0.12*** (0.02)	0.05** (0.02)	0.05** (0.02)	0.03 (0.03)	0.03 (0.03)	-0.05* (0.03)	-0.05* (0.03)
Neg. comment $\times$ Pos. article		-0.13** (0.05)		-0.06 (0.05)		0.12* (0.07)		-0.02 (0.05)
Observations	2,392	2,245	2,392	2,245	2,392	2,245	2,245	2,245

Heteroskedasticity-robust standard-errors in parentheses
Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1

Table A18: H1, H2 regression tables, full 2 $\times$ 2 sample.

Dependent Variables: Model:	Trust Media/Experts (1)	Politicians Care (2)	People-centrism (rev.) (3)	Disconnect (4)
Constant	3.0*** (0.23)	3.1*** (0.22)	2.7*** (0.33)	-3.5*** (0.24)
Neg. comment	-0.10 (0.08)	-0.09 (0.08)	-0.16 (0.12)	0.15 (0.09)
Pos. article	-0.29*** (0.08)	-0.07 (0.08)	-0.02 (0.11)	0.06 (0.09)
Econ pre	-0.05* (0.03)	0.04 (0.03)	0.01 (0.04)	-0.03 (0.03)
Will of the people (pre)	-0.06*** (0.02)	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.48*** (0.04)	0.30*** (0.03)
System stacked (pre)	-0.06*** (0.01)	-0.33*** (0.02)	-0.13*** (0.02)	0.29*** (0.02)
Officials care (pre, rev)	-0.08*** (0.02)	-0.43*** (0.02)	-0.10*** (0.02)	0.34*** (0.02)
News media fair (pre, rev)	-0.35*** (0.01)	-0.06*** (0.01)	0.006 (0.02)	0.04** (0.01)
Trust experts (pre, rev)	-0.42*** (0.01)	-0.02** (0.01)	-0.08*** (0.02)	0.06*** (0.01)
News interest	0.03* (0.01)	-0.0006 (0.01)	-0.04** (0.02)	0.02 (0.01)
Democrat	0.10** (0.04)	0.01 (0.04)	-0.14** (0.06)	0.07 (0.04)
Republican	-0.14*** (0.04)	0.02 (0.04)	-0.13** (0.06)	0.06 (0.05)
Education (yrs)	0.01*** (0.006)	-0.003 (0.005)	0.02*** (0.008)	-0.01* (0.006)
Log income	0.02 (0.02)	0.01 (0.01)	0.03 (0.02)	-0.03 (0.02)
Econ identity (pre)	-0.01 (0.02)	0.09*** (0.02)	0.02 (0.03)	-0.07*** (0.02)
Neg. comment $\times$ Pos. article	-0.10 (0.12)	-0.02 (0.11)	-0.02 (0.16)	0.03 (0.12)
Neg. comment $\times$ Econ pre	0.01 (0.03)	0.02 (0.03)	0.03 (0.04)	-0.03 (0.04)
Pos. article $\times$ Econ pre	0.12*** (0.03)	0.06* (0.03)	-0.008 (0.04)	-0.04 (0.04)
Neg. comment $\times$ Pos. article $\times$ Econ pre	-0.01 (0.05)	-0.02 (0.05)	0.07 (0.07)	-0.02 (0.05)
Observations	2,245	2,245	2,245	2,245

Heteroskedasticity-robust standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***, 0.01, **, 0.05, *, 0.1*

Table A19: RQ1: Triple interaction — comment tone $\times$ article tone $\times$ economic pessimism, full 2 $\times$ 2 sample.

D.3 Robustness: Alternative Specifications

Figure A16 presents a non-parametric version of H1 in which *econ_pre* is entered as a five-level factor rather than a linear continuous moderator. The average marginal effect of a positive article is estimated separately at each level.

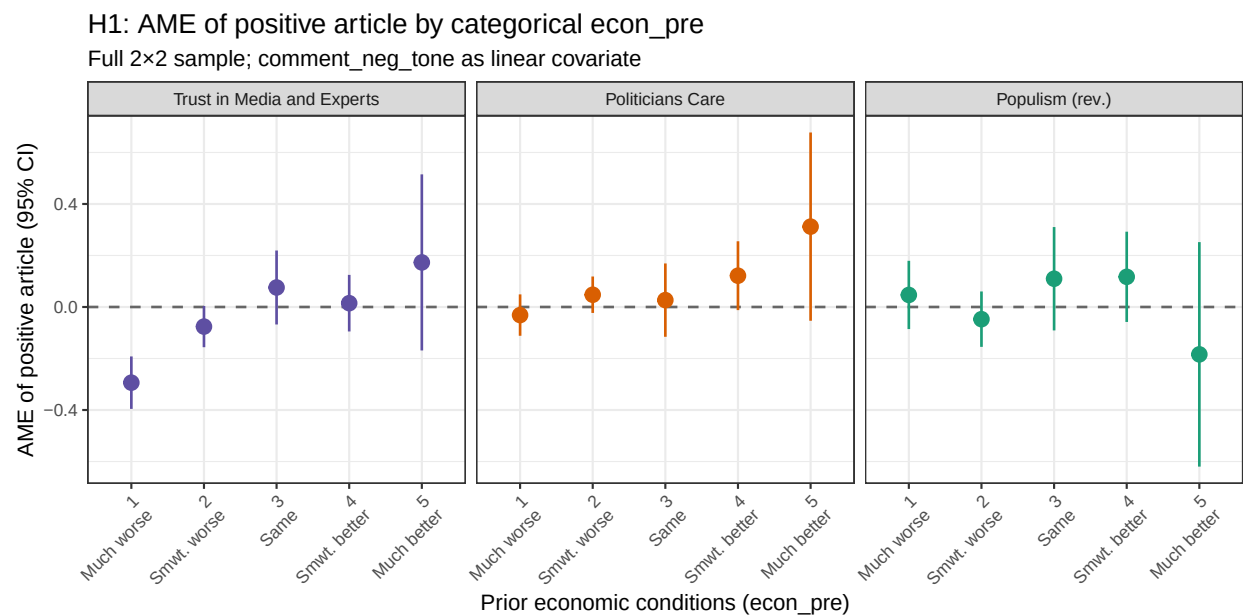


Figure A16: H1 article backlash: AME of positive article at each level of *econ_pre* (categorical). Full 2×2 sample; *comment_neg_tone* as linear covariate. Points show point estimates; bars show 95% CIs.

Table A20 reports regression coefficients for all robustness specifications. For H1 (article backlash), robustness specifications include removing covariate adjustment, including the full sample of respondents, restricting the data set to the neutral-comment condition as indicated in my preregistration, and using perceptions of the economic situation of “people like you” (economic identity) (Nagler, Zilinsky, and Linn, 2022) as an alternative H1 moderator. For H2 (comment mismatch), robustness specifications include removing covariate adjustment and including the full sample of respondents.

Dependent Variable: Model:	Trust Media/Experts						
	H1 unadj. (1)	H2 unadj. (2)	H1 no excl. (3)	H2 no excl. (4)	H1 neutral (5)	H1 econ_id. (6)	H1 cat. econ_pre (7)
Constant	0.47*** (0.07)	0.09** (0.04)	3.1*** (0.22)	2.9*** (0.22)	3.3*** (0.30)	3.1*** (0.22)	2.9*** (0.22)
Pos. article	-0.51*** (0.10)	-0.07 (0.06)	-0.36*** (0.06)	-0.04 (0.04)	-0.29*** (0.08)	-0.35*** (0.07)	-0.29*** (0.05)
Econ pre	-0.16*** (0.03)		-0.05** (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)	-0.03 (0.03)		
Neg. comment	-0.12*** (0.04)	-0.08 (0.06)	-0.14*** (0.03)	-0.09** (0.04)		-0.14*** (0.03)	-0.14*** (0.03)
Pos. article × Econ pre	0.18*** (0.04)		0.12*** (0.02)		0.12*** (0.03)		
Neg. comment × Pos. article		-0.08 (0.08)		-0.10** (0.05)			
Will of the people (pre)			-0.05*** (0.02)	-0.05*** (0.02)	-0.07** (0.03)	-0.06*** (0.02)	-0.05** (0.02)
System stacked (pre)			-0.06*** (0.01)	-0.06*** (0.01)	-0.08*** (0.02)	-0.06*** (0.01)	-0.06*** (0.01)
Officials care (pre, rev)			-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.05** (0.02)	-0.08*** (0.02)	-0.08*** (0.02)
News media fair (pre, rev)			-0.35*** (0.01)	-0.35*** (0.01)	-0.36*** (0.02)	-0.35*** (0.01)	-0.35*** (0.01)
Trust experts (pre, rev)			-0.43*** (0.01)	-0.43*** (0.01)	-0.45*** (0.02)	-0.43*** (0.01)	-0.42*** (0.01)
News interest			0.03** (0.01)	0.03** (0.01)	0.05** (0.02)	0.03* (0.01)	0.03** (0.02)
Democrat			0.13*** (0.04)	0.13*** (0.04)	0.13** (0.06)	0.09** (0.04)	0.11*** (0.04)
Republican			-0.11*** (0.04)	-0.11*** (0.04)	-0.14** (0.06)	-0.13*** (0.04)	-0.13*** (0.04)
Education (yrs)			0.01*** (0.006)	0.01*** (0.006)	0.02* (0.008)	0.01*** (0.006)	0.01*** (0.006)
Log income			0.006 (0.02)	0.009 (0.02)	-0.002 (0.02)	0.02 (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)
Econ identity (pre)			-0.01 (0.02)	-0.02 (0.02)	-0.03 (0.02)	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.01 (0.02)
Pos. article × Econ identity (pre)						0.11*** (0.03)	
Econ pre = 2							-0.01 (0.05)
Econ pre = 3							-0.08 (0.07)
Econ pre = 4							-0.07 (0.07)
Econ pre = 5							-0.34*** (0.11)
Pos. article × Econ pre = 2							0.22*** (0.07)
Pos. article × Econ pre = 3							0.37*** (0.09)
Pos. article × Econ pre = 4							0.31*** (0.08)
Pos. article × Econ pre = 5							0.47** (0.18)
Observations	2,249	2,249	2,392	2,392	1,126	2,245	2,245

Table A20: Robustness across specifications — trust in media and experts. Key coefficients: Pos. article × Econ pre (H1); Neg. comment × Pos. article (H2).

Dependent Variable: Model:	Politicians Care						
	H1 unadj. (1)	H2 unadj. (2)	H1 no excl. (3)	H2 no excl. (4)	H1 neutral (5)	H1 econ.id. (6)	H1 cat. econ_pre (7)
Constant	-0.73*** (0.07)	0.06 (0.04)	3.1*** (0.20)	3.0*** (0.20)	3.3*** (0.28)	3.2*** (0.21)	3.1*** (0.21)
Pos. article	-0.15* (0.09)	-0.01 (0.06)	-0.07 (0.05)	0.08** (0.03)	-0.06 (0.08)	-0.03 (0.06)	-0.03 (0.04)
Econ pre	0.35*** (0.03)		0.05** (0.02)	0.07*** (0.02)	0.07** (0.03)		
Neg. comment	-0.12*** (0.04)	-0.15*** (0.06)	-0.08*** (0.02)	-0.04 (0.03)		-0.08*** (0.02)	-0.08*** (0.02)
Pos. article × Econ pre	0.07* (0.04)		0.05** (0.02)		0.06* (0.03)		
Neg. comment × Pos. article		0.04 (0.08)		-0.07 (0.05)			
Will of the people (pre)			-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.10*** (0.03)	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.07*** (0.02)
System stacked (pre)			-0.33*** (0.01)	-0.33*** (0.01)	-0.34*** (0.02)	-0.34*** (0.02)	-0.33*** (0.02)
Officials care (pre, rev)			-0.43*** (0.02)	-0.43*** (0.02)	-0.41*** (0.03)	-0.44*** (0.02)	-0.42*** (0.02)
News media fair (pre, rev)			-0.06*** (0.01)	-0.06*** (0.01)	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.05*** (0.01)	-0.06*** (0.01)
Trust experts (pre, rev)			-0.02** (0.01)	-0.02** (0.01)	-0.04*** (0.02)	-0.02* (0.01)	-0.02* (0.01)
News interest			0.002 (0.01)	0.0006 (0.01)	0.01 (0.02)	3.5×10^{-5} (0.01)	-0.002 (0.01)
Democrat			0.03 (0.04)	0.03 (0.04)	-0.04 (0.06)	-0.007 (0.04)	0.01 (0.04)
Republican			0.03 (0.04)	0.03 (0.04)	-0.06 (0.06)	0.05 (0.04)	0.01 (0.04)
Education (yrs)			-0.004 (0.005)	-0.004 (0.005)	-0.006 (0.007)	-0.004 (0.005)	-0.003 (0.005)
Log income			0.01 (0.01)	0.01 (0.01)	0.02 (0.02)	0.01 (0.01)	0.01 (0.01)
Econ identity (pre)			0.09*** (0.02)	0.09*** (0.02)	0.05** (0.03)	0.11*** (0.02)	0.09*** (0.02)
Pos. article × Econ identity (pre)						0.03 (0.03)	
Econ pre = 2							0.02 (0.04)
Econ pre = 3							0.10 (0.07)
Econ pre = 4							0.17** (0.07)
Econ pre = 5							0.05 (0.15)
Pos. article × Econ pre = 2							0.08 (0.06)
Pos. article × Econ pre = 3							0.06 (0.08)
Pos. article × Econ pre = 4							0.15* (0.08)
Pos. article × Econ pre = 5							0.34* (0.19)
Observations	2,249	2,249	2,392	2,392	1,126	2,245	2,245

Table A21: Robustness across specifications — politicians care. Key coefficients: Pos. article × Econ pre (H1); Neg. comment × Pos. article (H2).

Dependent Variable: Model:	People-centrism (rev.)						
	H1 unadj. (1)	H2 unadj. (2)	H1 no excl. (3)	H2 no excl. (4)	H1 neutral (5)	H1 econ.id. (6)	H1 cat. econ_pre (7)
Constant	-0.31*** (0.07)	0.06 (0.04)	2.7*** (0.31)	2.7*** (0.31)	2.9*** (0.45)	2.7*** (0.32)	2.5*** (0.32)
Pos. article	-0.08 (0.09)	-0.10* (0.06)	-0.03 (0.08)	-0.01 (0.05)	-0.01 (0.11)	-0.02 (0.09)	0.05 (0.07)
Econ pre	0.14*** (0.03)		0.02 (0.03)	0.03 (0.02)	0.03 (0.04)		
Neg. comment	-0.04 (0.04)	-0.15** (0.06)	-0.05 (0.04)	-0.10** (0.05)		-0.04 (0.04)	-0.04 (0.04)
Pos. article × Econ pre	0.03 (0.04)		0.03 (0.03)		-0.01 (0.04)		
Neg. comment × Pos. article		0.20** (0.08)		0.11 (0.07)			
Will of the people (pre)			-0.48*** (0.04)	-0.48*** (0.04)	-0.57*** (0.05)	-0.48*** (0.04)	-0.47*** (0.04)
System stacked (pre)			-0.14*** (0.02)	-0.14*** (0.02)	-0.14*** (0.03)	-0.13*** (0.02)	-0.13*** (0.02)
Officials care (pre, rev)			-0.10*** (0.02)	-0.10*** (0.02)	-0.04 (0.03)	-0.11*** (0.02)	-0.10*** (0.02)
News media fair (pre, rev)			0.0008 (0.02)	0.0007 (0.02)	0.009 (0.03)	0.009 (0.02)	0.02 (0.02)
Trust experts (pre, rev)			-0.08*** (0.02)	-0.08*** (0.02)	-0.11*** (0.02)	-0.08*** (0.02)	-0.07*** (0.02)
News interest			-0.04** (0.02)	-0.04** (0.02)	-0.02 (0.03)	-0.04** (0.02)	-0.03 (0.02)
Democrat			-0.16*** (0.06)	-0.16*** (0.06)	-0.06 (0.08)	-0.15*** (0.06)	-0.13** (0.06)
Republican			-0.14** (0.06)	-0.14** (0.06)	-0.03 (0.08)	-0.12** (0.06)	-0.14** (0.06)
Education (yrs)			0.03*** (0.008)	0.03*** (0.008)	0.03*** (0.01)	0.02*** (0.008)	0.02*** (0.008)
Log income			0.03 (0.02)	0.03 (0.02)	0.01 (0.03)	0.03 (0.02)	0.02 (0.02)
Econ identity (pre)			0.02 (0.03)	0.01 (0.03)	0.01 (0.04)	0.03 (0.03)	0.03 (0.03)
Pos. article × Econ identity (pre)						0.02 (0.04)	
Econ pre = 2							0.17** (0.07)
Econ pre = 3							0.23** (0.10)
Econ pre = 4							0.13 (0.09)
Econ pre = 5							-0.09 (0.15)
Pos. article × Econ pre = 2							-0.09 (0.09)
Pos. article × Econ pre = 3							0.06 (0.12)
Pos. article × Econ pre = 4							0.07 (0.11)
Pos. article × Econ pre = 5							-0.23 (0.23)
Observations	2,249	2,249	2,392	2,392	1,126	2,245	2,245

Heteroskedasticity-robust standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table A22: Robustness across specifications — populism. Key coefficients: Pos. article × Econ pre (H1); Neg. comment × Pos. article (H2).

D.4 Item-Level Results

Dependent Variables: Model:	experts_claim		trust_experts_rev		news_trust_rev	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Constant	1.6*** (0.34)	1.7*** (0.34)	0.71*** (0.27)	0.89*** (0.27)	0.47** (0.24)	0.55** (0.24)
Pos. article	0.33*** (0.10)	0.03 (0.06)	0.33*** (0.07)	-0.02 (0.04)	0.21*** (0.06)	0.06 (0.04)
Econ pre	0.04 (0.03)	-0.01 (0.03)	0.03 (0.03)	-0.03 (0.02)	0.04** (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)
Neg. comment	0.14*** (0.04)	0.07 (0.06)	0.14*** (0.03)	0.07* (0.04)	0.06** (0.03)	0.04 (0.04)
Will of the people (pre)	0.11*** (0.03)	0.11*** (0.03)	0.03 (0.03)	0.03 (0.03)	0.001 (0.02)	0.0008 (0.02)
System stacked (pre)	0.10*** (0.02)	0.10*** (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)	0.04*** (0.01)	0.04*** (0.01)
Officials care (pre, rev)	0.11*** (0.03)	0.11*** (0.03)	0.03 (0.02)	0.03 (0.02)	0.05*** (0.02)	0.05*** (0.02)
News media fair (pre, rev)	0.10*** (0.02)	0.10*** (0.02)	0.04** (0.02)	0.04** (0.02)	0.74*** (0.02)	0.74*** (0.02)
Trust experts (pre, rev)	0.31*** (0.02)	0.31*** (0.02)	0.75*** (0.02)	0.75*** (0.02)	0.02 (0.01)	0.02 (0.01)
News interest	-0.02 (0.02)	-0.02 (0.02)	-0.006 (0.02)	-0.003 (0.02)	-0.04*** (0.02)	-0.04** (0.02)
Democrat	-0.14** (0.07)	-0.14** (0.06)	-0.13*** (0.05)	-0.13** (0.05)	0.02 (0.04)	0.02 (0.04)
Republican	0.16** (0.06)	0.17*** (0.06)	-0.03 (0.05)	-0.03 (0.05)	0.20*** (0.05)	0.21*** (0.05)
Education (yrs)	-0.02*** (0.009)	-0.02*** (0.009)	-0.007 (0.007)	-0.007 (0.007)	-0.008 (0.006)	-0.008 (0.006)
Log income	-0.01 (0.03)	-0.01 (0.03)	-0.04** (0.02)	-0.05** (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)	0.010 (0.02)
Econ identity (pre)	-0.001 (0.03)	-0.001 (0.03)	0.03 (0.02)	0.03 (0.02)	0.008 (0.02)	0.009 (0.02)
Pos. article × Econ pre	-0.10*** (0.04)		-0.13*** (0.03)		-0.06** (0.03)	
Neg. comment × Pos. article		0.15* (0.08)		0.15** (0.06)		0.03 (0.06)
Observations	2,245	2,245	2,245	2,245	2,245	2,245

Heteroskedasticity-robust standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table A23: Item-level results — trust in media and experts items. Odd columns: H1 spec (positive article × economic pessimism); even columns: H2 spec (negative comment × positive article).

Dependent Variables: Model:	system_stacked		public_officials_rev		econ_reality_rev	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Constant	1.6*** (0.27)	1.6*** (0.27)	0.57** (0.25)	0.64*** (0.25)	1.6*** (0.32)	1.7*** (0.32)
Pos. article	-0.09 (0.06)	-0.04 (0.04)	0.09 (0.07)	-0.06 (0.04)	0.20** (0.09)	-0.08 (0.06)
Econ pre	-0.06** (0.02)	-0.04** (0.02)	0.005 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.02)	-0.07** (0.03)	-0.12*** (0.03)
Neg. comment	0.04 (0.03)	0.03 (0.04)	0.02 (0.03)	-0.01 (0.04)	0.13*** (0.04)	0.10* (0.05)
Will of the people (pre)	0.05** (0.02)	0.05** (0.02)	0.05** (0.02)	0.05** (0.02)	0.07*** (0.03)	0.07*** (0.03)
System stacked (pre)	0.69*** (0.02)	0.69*** (0.02)	0.09*** (0.02)	0.09*** (0.02)	0.08*** (0.02)	0.08*** (0.02)
Officials care (pre, rev)	0.11*** (0.02)	0.11*** (0.02)	0.64*** (0.02)	0.64*** (0.02)	0.35*** (0.03)	0.35*** (0.03)
News media fair (pre, rev)	0.02 (0.01)	0.02 (0.01)	0.06*** (0.02)	0.06*** (0.02)	0.07*** (0.02)	0.07*** (0.02)
Trust experts (pre, rev)	0.03** (0.01)	0.03** (0.01)	0.01 (0.01)	0.01 (0.01)	0.01 (0.02)	0.02 (0.02)
News interest	0.02 (0.02)	0.02 (0.02)	-0.03* (0.02)	-0.03* (0.02)	0.02 (0.02)	0.02 (0.02)
Democrat	-0.10** (0.04)	-0.10** (0.04)	0.03 (0.05)	0.03 (0.05)	0.03 (0.06)	0.03 (0.06)
Republican	-0.12** (0.05)	-0.12** (0.05)	0.02 (0.05)	0.02 (0.05)	0.06 (0.06)	0.06 (0.06)
Education (yrs)	-0.01* (0.006)	-0.01* (0.006)	0.004 (0.006)	0.004 (0.006)	0.01 (0.008)	0.01 (0.008)
Log income	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.07*** (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)	0.02 (0.02)	0.02 (0.02)
Econ identity (pre)	-0.09*** (0.02)	-0.10*** (0.02)	-0.06** (0.02)	-0.06** (0.02)	-0.09*** (0.03)	-0.09*** (0.03)
Pos. article × Econ pre	0.02 (0.03)		-0.05* (0.03)		-0.11*** (0.04)	
Neg. comment × Pos. article		0.02 (0.06)		0.07 (0.06)		0.07 (0.07)
Observations	2,245	2,245	2,245	2,245	2,245	2,245

Heteroskedasticity-robust standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table A24: Item-level results — politicians care items. Odd columns: H1 spec; even columns: H2 spec.

Dependent Variables: Model:	willOf_ppl		good_corrupt		leader_represent	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Constant	1.5*** (0.25)	1.5*** (0.24)	2.4*** (0.39)	2.4*** (0.38)	2.9*** (0.31)	2.9*** (0.30)
Pos. article	0.05 (0.06)	0.05 (0.04)	-0.01 (0.11)	-0.02 (0.06)	0.001 (0.08)	0.04 (0.05)
Econ pre	0.01 (0.02)	0.006 (0.02)	-0.06 (0.04)	-0.06* (0.03)	-0.01 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.02)
Neg. comment	0.03 (0.03)	0.07* (0.04)	0.04 (0.05)	0.04 (0.07)	0.01 (0.04)	0.10* (0.05)
Will of the people (pre)	0.53*** (0.03)	0.53*** (0.03)	0.19*** (0.04)	0.19*** (0.04)	0.26*** (0.03)	0.26*** (0.03)
System stacked (pre)	0.04** (0.01)	0.04** (0.01)	0.16*** (0.03)	0.16*** (0.03)	0.07*** (0.02)	0.07*** (0.02)
Officials care (pre, rev)	0.05*** (0.02)	0.04*** (0.02)	0.12*** (0.03)	0.12*** (0.03)	0.04* (0.02)	0.04* (0.02)
News media fair (pre, rev)	0.007 (0.01)	0.007 (0.01)	0.01 (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)	-0.03* (0.02)	-0.03* (0.02)
Trust experts (pre, rev)	0.02* (0.01)	0.02** (0.01)	0.09*** (0.02)	0.09*** (0.02)	0.05*** (0.02)	0.05*** (0.02)
News interest	0.05*** (0.02)	0.05*** (0.02)	0.03 (0.03)	0.03 (0.03)	0.003 (0.02)	0.002 (0.02)
Democrat	0.06 (0.04)	0.06 (0.04)	0.18** (0.08)	0.18** (0.08)	0.05 (0.06)	0.05 (0.06)
Republican	-0.02 (0.05)	-0.02 (0.05)	0.16** (0.08)	0.16** (0.08)	0.14** (0.06)	0.13** (0.06)
Education (yrs)	0.002 (0.006)	0.002 (0.006)	-0.03*** (0.01)	-0.03*** (0.01)	-0.02** (0.008)	-0.02** (0.008)
Log income	-0.004 (0.02)	-0.004 (0.02)	-0.06** (0.03)	-0.06** (0.03)	0.001 (0.02)	0.001 (0.02)
Econ identity (pre)	-0.005 (0.02)	-0.004 (0.02)	-0.008 (0.03)	-0.008 (0.03)	-0.03 (0.03)	-0.03 (0.03)
Pos. article × Econ pre	-0.02 (0.03)		-0.004 (0.04)		-0.02 (0.03)	
Neg. comment × Pos. article		-0.07 (0.05)		-0.005 (0.09)		-0.17** (0.07)
Observations	2,245	2,245	2,245	2,245	2,245	2,245

Heteroskedasticity-robust standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table A25: Item-level results — populism items. Odd columns: H1 spec; even columns: H2 spec.

D.5 Comparison to Ladd (2012)

Table A26: Effect of Elite Criticism on Media Feeling Thermometer (SD units)

	(1) Average effect	(2) Same-party interaction	(3) Resp. $\times$ Critic party cells
Any elite criticism	-0.157 [†] (0.093)	-0.076 (0.104)	
$\times$ Same-party match		-0.180 (0.111)	
Dem resp. $\times$ Dem critic			-0.318* (0.140)
Dem resp. $\times$ Rep critic			-0.017 (0.143)
Rep resp. $\times$ Dem critic			-0.115 (0.142)
Rep resp. $\times$ Rep critic			-0.200 (0.148)
Other treatment arms	Yes	Yes	Yes
Respondent party FE		Yes	Yes
<i>N</i>	1002	1002	926

Notes: Replication of Ladd (2012) Appendix Table 5-1. Outcome is feeling thermometer toward the news media, standardized by its sample SD ($\sigma \approx 22.5$). All models estimated via weighted OLS using survey weights. Column (1) regresses the standardized outcome on a pooled *any-elite-criticism* indicator. Column (2) decomposes that effect into the baseline elite-criticism response (for Independents and partisans receiving other-party criticism) and an additional shift for partisans receiving own-party criticism. Column (3) replaces the pooled criticism dummy with cell indicators for every (respondent-party $\times$ criticism-party) combination, restricted to partisan respondents. Other treatment arms (tabloid coverage, both-side criticism, horserace coverage) and a respondent-party fixed effect are included where indicated. Standard errors in parentheses. [†] $p < 0.10$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

Dependent Variables: Model:	Trust Media/Experts (1)	Politicians Care (2)	People-centrism (rev.) (3)
Constant	2.9*** (0.22)	3.3*** (0.20)	2.7*** (0.31)
Pos. article	-0.16*** (0.03)	0.01 (0.03)	-0.01 (0.04)
Neutral (3)	-0.10* (0.06)	0.11* (0.06)	0.12 (0.08)
Positive (4-5)	-0.14*** (0.05)	0.21*** (0.06)	0.008 (0.07)
Neg. comment	-0.14*** (0.03)	-0.08*** (0.02)	-0.04 (0.04)
Will of the people (pre)	-0.05*** (0.02)	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.48*** (0.04)
System stacked (pre)	-0.06*** (0.01)	-0.36*** (0.02)	-0.14*** (0.02)
Officials care (pre, rev)	-0.08*** (0.02)	-0.43*** (0.02)	-0.11*** (0.02)
News media fair (pre, rev)	-0.35*** (0.01)	-0.07*** (0.01)	0.009 (0.02)
Trust experts (pre, rev)	-0.43*** (0.01)	-0.02* (0.01)	-0.08*** (0.02)
News interest	0.03* (0.02)	-0.0005 (0.01)	-0.03 (0.02)
Democrat	0.10** (0.04)	0.002 (0.04)	-0.14** (0.06)
Republican	-0.12*** (0.04)	0.03 (0.04)	-0.12** (0.06)
Education (yrs)	0.01*** (0.006)	0.0006 (0.005)	0.02*** (0.008)
Log income	0.01 (0.02)	0.03* (0.01)	0.04 (0.02)
Pos. article $\times$ Neutral	0.24*** (0.08)	0.02 (0.08)	0.12 (0.11)
Pos. article $\times$ Positive	0.20*** (0.06)	0.13* (0.07)	0.08 (0.09)
Observations	2,245	2,245	2,245

Heteroskedasticity-robust standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table A27: Results for H1 (positive article $\times$ economic pessimism) bucketed by pre-treatment economic perceptions: negative and positive perceptions grouped together to facilitate comparison to Ladd (2012).